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Pure Politics, Bottom Line & Around the World



ET WEALTH ON MONDAY



The Economic Times PRESENTS THE QUEST

Concert Play and the Next Act

Sruthijith KK talks to BookMyShow founder **Ashish Hemrajani** about India's ₹25,000-crore concert economy, ticket scalping, the rise of Indian music superstars, Bollywood's troubles, competition from District and the future of BookMyShow.

Available on EconomicTimes.com/podcast, Amazon Prime Music, Apple Podcasts, JioSaavn *and* Spotify.

PROMOTER JUBILANT TO RETAIN STAKE

Coca-Cola India's Bottling Arm HCCH Files DRHP for IPO

Proposed $1-billion listing will be fully through 997.5 million shares on offer

Our Bureau

New Delhi | Mumbai: Coca-Cola India's bottling arm plans to hold its much-anticipated initial public offering (IPO) next year, with the US beverage giant cutting its 60% stake in the unit to 45%. The Hindustan Coca-Cola Holdings Ltd (HCCH) IPO, pegged at $1 billion, will entirely be an offer for sale (OFS) of 997.5 million shares, according to the draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) filed by the company with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi).

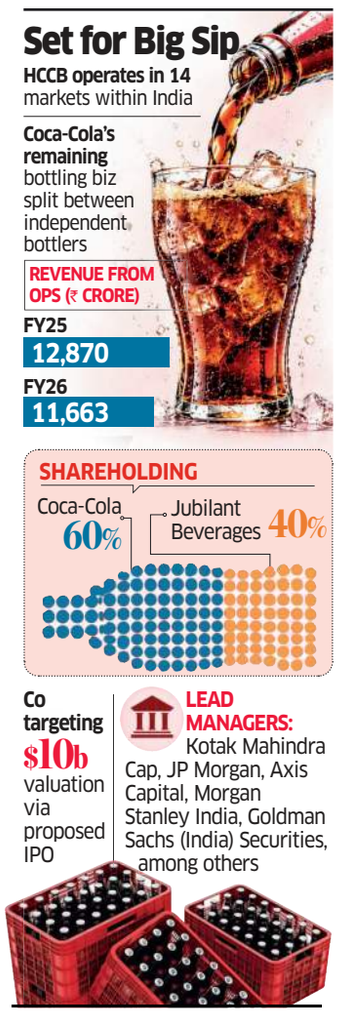
The 40% stake of Jubilant Beverages, which became a promoter of the company in July 2025, will remain unchanged, according to the DRHP. The listing plan is in line with Coca-Cola's global strategy of following an asset-light operating model and focusing on strategy, brand building and digitisation. The Jubilant Bhartia Group had acquired the 40% stake in HCCH for ₹12,500 crore. The $1 billion IPO estimate puts the company's valuation at about $10 billion.

Rival PepsiCo's bottling partner Varun Beverages Ltd (VBL) listed a decade ago and has a current mcap of ₹1.48 lakh crore ($15.74 billion).

Prominent consumer-facing global companies that have tapped public markets over the past two years include Hyundai Motors India and LG Electronics, both of which had record listings.

HCCH, the holding company of Hindustan Coca-Cola Beverages Pvt Ltd (HCCB), manufactures, distributes and sells Coca-Cola, Thums Up and Sprite aerated drinks, Maaza juices, Kinley and Dasani water and Georgia coffee. The company operates in 10 states and four Union Territories, primarily in southern and western India.

Core Growth Market ▸▸ 5



CUSTOMERS' EXPOSURE TO DIVERSE CUISINES FUELS DEMAND

Flavour of the Season
Mithai Out of the Box

Desi sweets with modern ingredients for premium gifting gain traction

Nupur Amarnath

Bengaluru: Coffee hazelnut peda, rose-and-orange kaju rolls, kalakand biscoff, boondi lemon tarts and kesar kulfi-flavoured chocolate bars — the Diwali sweet box has finally got a mithai makeover.

Traditional mithai is being folded into pastry, layered into butter biscuits and paired with coffee, fruit and dark chocolate as sweet makers court buyers seeking something different for their festive tables and gifting.

The experimentation is finding takers: Bombay Sweet Shop reports 80% growth in its Diwali business over last year, while brands like Dzurt, Sage & Saffron and IKAI report stronger interest from individual customers and corporate gifting clients seeking alternatives to the conventional sweet box.

The opportunity remains small relative to India's sweets market, which multiple news reports peg at Rs 84,310 crore. Premium mithai is less than 1% of the market, where fusion mithai is an even smaller part. But within it, this Diwali, brands have reported rising demand.

Emotional Connect ▸▸ 5



COS OFFER PERSONAL TRAINERS TO MULTI-CITY GYM MEMBERSHIPS

Workout after Work: India Inc Flexes its Fitness Muscle

Employers make workplace wellness harder to skip

Brinda Sarkar & Sreeradha Basu

Bengaluru: Looking to work off those Diwali indulgences? Your workplace could be the place to start. From well-equipped gyms and group classes to memberships across city-wide networks, employers are making it easier for employees to fit fitness into their working day.

Companies such as Procter & Gamble, InMobi, Walmart Global Tech and HSBC India are expanding workplace fitness initiatives. Providers say the focus is shifting from just providing fitness as an employee perk to getting people to use it.

Wide Range of Offerings ▸▸ 5



Perks Get Physical

- **Cult for Corporates** says cos now make up over **25% of its enterprise volume**
- **Fit.Zone reports** membership **enquiries up about 15% YoY**
- **Demand for on-site** facilities strongest at large tech campuses, manufacturing hubs

PUREPOLITICS

PAGE ▸▸ 2

Nepal PM Seeks $2b Aid Ahead of India Visit

Nepal is preparing to seek a $2 billion package from India, comprising lines of credit and grants, ahead of PM Balen Shah's visit to India during November 22 -24. The Nepal government has held internal talks on it likely during foreign secretary Vikram Misri's visit, reports **Dipanjan Roy Chaudhury**.

Killings, Arson in Manipur: Search Ops on

Joint teams of Manipur Police, CRPF as well as its CoBRA unit, BSF, Assam Rifles and the army are conducting cordon and search operations in the state to identify and apprehend those involved in recent killings of civilians and incidents of arson, **Bikash Singh** reports.

IAF Heavy-lifter Makes World Record Landing

An Indian Air Force IL-76MD heavy-lift transport aircraft marked the highest-altitude landing achieved by the aircraft anywhere in the world after successfully touching down at the Nyoma airbase in eastern Ladakh, at an altitude of around 13,629 feet.

AP



Sands of Time

The installation of a Chinese artist "It is time to plant love" during the sixth edition of "Forever Is Now" contemporary art exhibition at Giza Pyramids in Egypt on Saturday

Pharma Heirs Eye Long-term Strategic Shifts

At India's family-run pharmaceutical companies such as Sun Pharma, Bharat Biotech and Laurus Labs, next-gen entrepreneurs are committing capital to new businesses with longer timelines, deeper scientific requirements and a starkly different set of risks, reports **Shilpa Ranipeta**. ▸▸ 9

Wigmakers Face Blues as Tirumala Tresses Get Dyed

At Tirumala temple in Andhra Pradesh, the changing colour of hair offered by devotees may be saying more about fashion than faith. The share of high-priced natural black hair – the most coveted category among wigmakers – has nearly halved over the past 3 years. **Shantanu Nandan Sharma** reports. ▸▸ 9

SEVEN PROPOSALS SUBMITTED FOR DISCUSSIONS

Climate Finance, Trade Likely to be on COP31 Table



African negotiators call for talks on funds needed by developing nations, protectionist steps tied to green action

Urmi Goswami

New Delhi: A face-off over formal discussions on finance and trade could mark the start of UN climate talks at COP31. Countries and negotiating groups have submitted seven proposals for inclusion in the formal agenda of the discussions that begin Monday.

The most contentious issues centre around finance, including money that developed countries must provide developing countries. Australia, as president of the negotiations, has been working to arrive at an understanding that addresses these concerns ahead of the formal opening.

COP31, the 31st Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), will be held in the Turkish city of Antalya on November 9-20. Under a joint partnership accord, Australia is heading intergovernmental negotiations.

The African Group of Negotiators, representing 54 African countries, wants a formal discussion on finance for adapting to the impact of climate change. It has called for the UN climate process to assess the amount of funds required by developing countries to form the basis of the resource mobilisation for the Green Climate Fund. Countries agreed to setting up the fund in 2010 at the climate talks in Cancun. Although the agreement was for the UN climate process to determine and inform the target for each round of mobilisation, this has never happened. The third replenishment period of the Green Climate Fund begins in January 2028.

These proposals are separate from the appeal by COP30 president Andre Correa do Lago in June, seeking the formalisation of a decision adopted in Belem, Brazil, to set up a two-year long work programme on climate finance, particularly the obligation of developed countries to provide developing countries with funds.

Mountain Ecosystems ▸▸ 5

For Things Money Can't Buy, There's a Concierge Card

The ultimate luxury for wealthy Indians is finding the impossible. Premium concierge services are doing it for them

Lijee Philip

Mumbai: In 1917, Pierre Cartier acquired a mansion on New York's Fifth Avenue in exchange for a double-strand natural pearl necklace, reportedly valued at $1 million at the time, and a nominal cash payment. More than a century later, the same necklace is the object of an extraordinary pursuit, with luxury concierge firm Sulit Lifestyle trying to track it down for one of its ultra-high-net-worth clients in India.

What do you buy someone who already has everything? Increasingly, for India's ultra-rich, the answer lies in objects that are hard to buy, even for those who can afford them. From historically significant jewellery and limited-edition watches to exceptionally rare pieces of Hermès Birkin, the hunt for elusive luxury goods is creating a niche business for concierge firms.

Requests to source rare products have increased by about 30% over the past 12-18 months, according to industry executives.

"Finding such rare, historically significant pieces requires access, persistence and the right connections," said Karan Chopra, managing director of Sulit Lifestyle.

The search for Cartier's necklace, for example, involves reaching out to private collectors, examining auction archives and approaching jewellery houses, he added.

Not every request, however, involves an object with a century-old history. Sometimes, speed matters as much as rarity. Chopra recalled a client who wanted a Richard Mille RM 011 Felipe Massa Flyback Chronograph as a gift for his wife at the earliest.

Hefty Sums for Speed, Exclusivity ▸▸ 5



HAPPYDIWALI



BSF personnel at Dakshin Dinajpur in West Bengal on Saturday –PTI



Kids at an orphanage in Jammu on Saturday –AP

BALEN SHAH TO VISIT INDIA FROM NOV 22 TO 24

Nepal PM Seeks $2B Package Ahead of Visit

Shah to focus on $1b in lines of credit, $1b in grants & infra projects

Dipanjan Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: Nepal is preparing to seek a $2 billion economic package from India, comprising lines of credit and grants, ahead of Prime Minister Balen Shah's visit to India from November 22 to 24.

The Nepal government has held internal discussions on the package, which is understood to have been discussed during foreign secretary Vikram Misri's visit to Kathmandu this week, ET has learnt.

The proposed package includes $1 billion in lines of credit for power and other infrastructure projects in the Himalayan nation, according to sources in Kathmandu.

Nepal is also seeking a $500 million grant from India to upgrade the Siddhartha Highway, which connects Sunauli on the Indian border with Pokhara. Another $500 million grant is being sought for post-flood reconstruction, ET has learnt.



Over the past seven decades, India-Nepal development cooperation has expanded and diversified across sectors such as health, education, power, archives, archaeology, connectivity, trade, agriculture, cultural heritage preservation and capacity building.

Projects under the bilateral development partnership are based on Nepal's needs and priorities and are spread across the country, an official told ET.

During Shah's visit, Nepal will also push for additional air routes between the two countries. It has been seeking to facilitate international flights to Gautam Buddha International Airport in Bhairahawa and Pokhara International Airport.

The Pancheshwar Multipurpose Project, conceived under the 1996 Mahakali Treaty, is another item on the agenda for Shah's visit. Several India-funded projects are expected to be inaugurated during the visit.



IAF's Heavy-Lifter Hits New High at Ladakh's Nyoma

PHOTO JUNCTION

An Indian Air Force IL-76MD heavy-lift transport aircraft of Russian origin successfully lands at the Nyoma airbase in eastern Ladakh, at an altitude of around 13,629 ft, marking the highest-altitude landing achieved by the aircraft anywhere in the world, the IAF said. The airbase is located about 25 km from the Line of Actual Control with China. The IAF described the touchdown as a "milestone that reinforces India's strategic airlift capability" and reasserts the aim of "pushing boundaries, redefining limits and making history". – OPB

TO IDENTIFY THOSE BEHIND CIVILIAN KILLINGS AND ARSON

Manipur Police, CRPF, BSF, Assam Rifles & Army Launch Search Ops

Bikash Singh

Guwahati: Security forces in Manipur have launched search operations to identify and apprehend those involved in recent killings of civilians and incidents of arson.

Efforts are ongoing to identify those involved in the crime and witnesses are being located and questioned, the Manipur Police said in a release.

Joint teams of the state police, CRPF including its CoBRA unit, BSF, Assam Rifles and the army are conducting cordon and search operations as well as intelligence-based operations in the affected areas, the police said.

"Necessary action is also being taken up with the National Investigation Agency. Police and all security forces are taking the matter with utmost concern," the police said in the release issued Friday evening.

They also advised "the public to remain calm, exercise restraint and not take the law into their own hands", and "not to believe or circulate unverified information, rumours or provocative content on social media".

A six-day shutdown called by the Committee on Tribal Unity in Manipur's Kangpokpi district was put on hold for a week on Friday, after the state government met some of the demands of the Kuki organisation and assured them it would address the rest.

The committee called for the shutdown from Sunday after the mutilated bodies of two young men who went missing last week near Taphou Kuki village were found in a hilly area of neighbouring Senapati district.

The shutdown had severely disrupted the movement of goods trucks along National Highway 2, leaving several vehicles stranded in Senapati district.

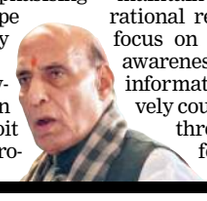
Four Siang Dam Protesters Released

Itanagar: Four protesters detained over the proposed 11,200-MW Siang Upper Multipurpose Project (SUMP) in Arunachal Pradesh were released from Jully Central Jail near Itanagar on Saturday, nearly a month after their arrest, officials said. –PTI

From Eastern Airbase, Rajnath Calls for Highest Readiness

New Delhi: India's armed forces must maintain the highest level of operational readiness to effectively counter any threats to national security, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said on Saturday, delivering his message from a key airbase near the frontier with China in the Eastern sector.

Addressing air warriors at the Bagdogra Air Force station, Singh, without naming any country, said the adversary avoids direct confrontation but seeks to exploit certain "vulnerabilities", emphasising that the security landscape has become increasingly complex.



"Often, the adversary avoids direct confrontation and instead seeks to exploit our vulnerabilities. Through social media, the adversary may attempt to sow doubt in the minds of the local population and our soldiers by spreading misleading information," he said.

"In such a scenario, your role extends beyond that of an ordinary soldier," he said.

Singh called upon the military to "maintain the highest level of operational readiness", with special focus on strengthening domain awareness, cyber resilience and information integrity to effectively counter emerging security threats, according to the defence ministry. — PTI

OTHER NEWS OF THE DAY

Stubble Burning Cases Cross 3,000 in Punjab

Chandigarh: The number of stubble burning incidents in Punjab has crossed the 3,000 mark, with Tarn Taran, Ferozepur and Sangrur accounting for the bulk of the cases, the Punjab Pollution Control Board said on Saturday. According to the PPCB data, the state recorded 3,144 farm fire incidents between September 15 and November 6, up from 2,787 cases reported till November 5. Tarn Taran reported the highest number of farm fires at 611, followed by Ferozepur at 410, Sangrur at 281, Bathinda at 262 and Amritsar at 231, the data showed. – PTI

Annual Ban on Vehicles Below BS-VI in Delhi

New Delhi: The Delhi government on Saturday said it will implement the ban on vehicles below BS-VI emission standards registered in other states or Union territories every year between November 1 and January 31.

It earlier announced a ban on the plying of non-Delhi-registered motor vehicles that are below BS-VI emission norms for the same period this year -- which is usually marked by the worst of the city's air pollution and quality -- under its Winter Action Plan to limit vehicular emissions and curb dust on roads. – PTI

Statement

Kumar Anshuman

BJP & JDU to Show Unity at PM Modi's Bihar Rally

BJP and JD(U) sought to project unity ahead of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's November 21 rally in Bihar, holding a meeting of NDA partners amid tensions over the recent MLC election results.

Modi will address a public meeting in Vaishali to mark the completion of one year of NDA government under BJP leadership in the state.

The meeting of all NDA leaders, held at the residence of chief minister Samrat Choudhary on Thursday, came after JD(U) leaders accused BJP of failing to support the alliance's candidates in the elections. The induction of two independents who defeated JD(U) candidates into BJP had further upset former chief minister Nitish Kumar's party.



Yet, all alliance partners presented a happy picture after the meeting.

"All the NDA partners discussed how to make the PM's event a memorable one," state BJP president Sanjay Saraogi told ET.

Saraogi also said there are "absolutely no issues" among the five NDA parties, including BJP, JD(U), LJP(R), HAM and RLM.

JDU state chief Kushwaha also said the focus is now on Modi's programme. "It is a great honour for Vaishali" that the PM has chosen to hold his rally there, he told ET.

Earlier on Thursday, the JD(U) leadership held a meeting in Patna to review the MLC elections loss. Some of the participants openly blamed the BJP for their debacle, party insiders told ET.

MP Speaker Gets 2 Months to Decide on MLA Disqualification

Another case of anti-defection law has come to the fore, with the Supreme Court directing Madhya Pradesh assembly speaker Narendra Singh Tomar to decide within two months on a disqualification petition against MLA Nirmala Sapre.

Sapre was elected from the Bina assembly constituency on a Congress ticket in 2023. During the 2024 Lok Sabha election campaign, however, she shared a stage with Madhya Pradesh chief minister Mohan Yadav and announced that she would join BJP.



The Supreme Court directive issued on Wednesday came in a petition filed by Congress leader of opposition in assembly Umang Singhar.

Singhar had initially filed a disqualification petition against Sapre before the assembly speaker. Later, he moved the Madhya Pradesh High Court, arguing that the speaker was delaying the proceeding. The High Court dismissed his plea, saying Sapre had denied joining BJP and leaving Congress and it is for the speaker to decide on the case.

"This is a classic case of death knell of the 10th Schedule of the Constitution," Vivek Tankha, Congress leader and lawyer who argued for the case in SC, told ET.

Omar Faces Questions Over Leadership As MP Resigns



VARANI SAHU

National Conference is facing growing internal dissent, with some MLAs questioning chief minister Omar Abdullah's leadership following the resignation of Aga Ruhullah as Srinagar MP on Friday.

The developments have forced party president Farooq Abdullah to intervene, calming the dissident legislators' tempers and assuring action on their demands at a meeting on Saturday.

The party leadership has sought to portray Ruhullah's resignation as a success of BJP's alleged "Operation Lotus" in Kashmir even as the discontent appears to go beyond the MP's departure, with legislators raising concerns about the CM's style of functioning and the influence of his close aides.

"There is a crisis of trust," a disgruntled MLA said, alleging that Abdullah listens only "to his friends and those who speak English and drink coffee."

The appointment of Nasir Aslam Wani as an advisor to the CM has emerged as a source of resentment.

Another NC legislator said Farooq Abdullah may have groomed his son as his successor, but Omar is yet to get a grip on how to "talk to a colleague" or handle a "political crisis."

PAWAR DISCHARGED

BJP Says Sharad Pawar, Sunetra to Decide on NCP Merger

Our Political Bureau

Mumbai: BJP has stepped into the debate over a possible merger of the two Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) factions, asserting that the decision rests with Sharad Pawar and Maharashtra deputy chief minister Sunetra Pawar.

While NCP (SP) leaders like Rohit Pawar insist that a reunion is off the table and NCP president Sunetra Pawar, wife of the late Ajit Pawar, maintains silence, BJP leaders like Pravin Darekar and Navnath Ban on Saturday dismissed objections raised by other leaders.

"We are not looking at the statements of the lower rung leaders seriously," Darekar said a day after Rohit Pawar ruled out the possibility of a merger.

"The merger of the two NCP's will not be determined by anyone else but by Sharad Pawar of the NCP(SP) and Sunetra Pawar. In the end, the lower rung leaders cannot take this decision," Darekar said. His remarks came amid renewed speculation following NCP leader Praful Patel's recent meeting with Sharad Pawar, who was recovering at Breach Candy Hospital. Pawar was discharged on Saturday.

DEMANDING ACTION

Rahul Gandhi Asks PM to Clarify on Ethanol Blending Level

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday asked Prime Minister Narendra Modi to clarify how much ethanol is being blended into petrol and when action would be taken against companies "mixing more than 20%".

Gandhi opened this front a day after a minister in the Congress government of Karnataka claimed "independent" sample studies done in the state found ethanol blends exceeding the prescribed 20% limit, a charge subsequently denied by oil marketing companies such as HPCL, IOC and BPCL. "E20 turned into 420–stealing petrol from the public's cars! The Modi government says--petrol contains 20% ethanol. The Karnataka government collected petrol samples from 7 districts and had them tested at an accredited lab. Look at the results--11 out of 14 samples contained more than 20% ethanol; whether government-owned or private, all exceeded the limit", Gandhi alleged in a social media post. This, he said, meant people are paying for expensive petrol, but ethanol is being pumped into their tanks despite cars not being designed to handle that much ethanol.

AMID ATTACKS

Bring Bulldozers, Run Them Over Me: Mamata Dares BJP

Kolkata: Condemning the attack on the residence of Diamond Harbour MP Abhishek Banerjee, former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee on Saturday "dared" the BJP to use its bulldozers against her, as she vowed to continue raising her voice against "atrocities and intimidation".

Banerjee alleged that BJP-backed miscreants, accompanied by police personnel, had targeted Abhishek Banerjee's residence in the Kalighat area in the early hours.

"How many bulldozers do you have? Bring them all. If you have the courage, come and run your bulldozers over my body. I am standing right here... Run your bulldozer over my chest if you dare," she said, protesting alleged police harassment and restrictions in her neighbourhood amid the attack.

Banerjee alleged that the incident reflected a wider atmosphere of "lawlessness and intimidation" in the state.

"At 2 am or 3 am, 'BJP lumpens', along with the police, are attacking people's homes. Why are you bringing lumpen elements and attacking homes in the middle of the night," she asked. — PTI

NARENDRA MODI

Bharat Ratna LK Advani Ji at 100

Shri Lal Krishna Advani Ji enters his hundredth year today (November 8), with his birthday coinciding with Diwali, a festival associated with Prabhu Shri Ram and the diya. The occasion comes amid celebrations marking 75 years of the Jana Sangh, the 125th Jayanti of Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee and the RSS centenary.

Few people have touched as many chapters of modern India as Advani Ji. Born on November 8, 1927, on Dev Deepawali, he experienced the pain of leaving behind his familiar world in Sindh in 1947. He rebuilt his life from scratch, without bitterness. This ability to build against all odds remained a defining trait, evident in his efforts to strengthen the Jana Sangh and later build the BJP. During his tenures as BJP president, the Congress's tally fell from 400 to below 200 in 1989, while the BJP emerged as the single largest party in 1996. He nurtured generations of Karyakartas and rooted the party in the principle of Nation First.

Two qualities set Advani Ji apart: ideological clarity and intellectual sharpness, reflected in his speeches, writings and incisive interviews. The Jana Sangh and BJP resolutions he authored remain relevant even today. He also consistently challenged the pseudo-secularism espoused by a large section of the Indian polity.

Advani Ji discharged every responsibility with great diligence. After serving as an RSS Pracharak in different parts of Rajasthan, he moved to Delhi and began working closely with Atal Ji. The two worked together for decades, cooperating without becoming competitors, setting a remarkable example of political partnership and changing the course of Indian politics.

The Delhi Advani Ji arrived in was still grappling with the horrors of Partition. He immersed himself in strengthening the Jana Sangh. In 1967, he became Chairman of the Delhi Metropolitan Council, working alongside the late Vijay Kumar Malhotra Ji.

Advani Ji's parliamentary innings began in 1970, and his interventions earned appreciation across the political spectrum. He made his mark as an MP, Leader of Opposition in both Houses and later from the treasury benches. Despite his parliamentary commitments, he frequently travelled across the country to meet people.







I vividly recall the 1991 Lok Sabha elections, when Advani Ji contested from two seats, including Gandhinagar. With his father having settled in Kutch after Partition and his earlier stint as a Rajya Sabha MP from Gujarat, it was a homecoming of sorts. I had the honour of helping prepare his papers and assisting him during the campaign. Gandhinagar elected him time and again, and as a voter, I too had the privilege of voting for him on several occasions. His commitment to his constituency remains a lesson in public service.

The Emergency was a watershed moment in Advani Ji's life. He was at the forefront of the struggle to save democracy and protect the Constitution. His experiences were captured in his book, A Prisoner's Scrap-Book. In a section titled 'A Tale of Two Emergencies', he drew parallels between events in India from June 1975 and those in Nazi Germany in 1933.

Advani Ji was a fiery Opposition leader but an equally excellent administrator. In 1977, he became Information and Broadcasting Minister in the Janata government, where his work was widely recognised. As Deputy Prime Minister and one of India's longest-serving Home Ministers, he helped strengthen the country's security apparatus and improve the lives of security personnel. His firm stand against terrorism also led to the enactment of a tough anti-terror law.

An iconic moment in Advani Ji's life was the Somnath-to-Ayodhya Rath Yatra, which changed the course of Indian society. I consider it a privilege to have been involved from its ideation to execution. Being present at Somnath when it began was particularly special. A *yatra* can be very demanding, requiring long hours, constant travel, and an ability to remain focused despite fatigue. Advani Ji embodied this endurance.

I also have memories of the saddening moments of Advani Ji's arrest in Bihar. Then, in Gujarat, the BJP withdrew support from the Chimanbhai Patel Government. With this, a simple message was given, that when it comes to our ideology and the Ram Temple, there will never be any compromise. Many of our senior leaders and Karyakartas took an oath that, come what may, a Ram Temple will be built. And, years later, with the blessings of the people of India, a grand *mandir* for Prabhu Shri Ram became a reality in Ayodhya.

There is so much more of Advani Ji that is outstanding. His simplicity, for example. After the Navnirman Movement, Advani Ji had come to Junagadh and stayed for a month as an ordinary Karyakarta, preparing the Party for the Assembly elections in which Congress was rejected. He has always shown what probity in public life is about. He is a voracious reader. Those who have spent time with him know how carefully he goes through newspapers. He is a big fan of cinema and theatre, and has been an enthusiastic film critic. His sense of history and the need to preserve it is visible in his book, 'My Country My Life.'

Advani Ji always remained in touch with Sindhi culture. Another effort he undertook was the popularisation of Sindhu Darshan Puja near Leh. I myself had been to one Puja with Advani Ji and George Fernandes Ji.

Any account of Advani Ji's remarkable journey would be incomplete without mentioning Kamla Advani Ji. She was a constant source of strength and support throughout his public life.

Growing up in Karachi, Advani Ji could hardly have imagined the path his life would take. In an expression of gratitude, the people of India conferred upon him the Bharat Ratna in 2024. As Advani Ji enters the hundredth year of his life, I pray that he be blessed with good health and that he continues to inspire us all as he has always done.

The writer is Prime Minister of India

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Why Did You Come Back?

India may have the largest diaspora but only a tiny share of its people lives abroad. Yet leaving the country is considered a metric of success, and homecoming met with puzzlement

Vedica Kant

Since I moved back to India, the question I get asked the most, usually with a slightly puzzled look, is, "Why did you come back?" It is asked as if living abroad had to mean leaving for good, and coming home needed explaining.

In a much-shared thread on X last month, the venture investor Deedy Das argued that "the smartest Indians continue to come to build in the US" because the economic incentives are far better. He listed close to 20 AI companies with at least one India-born founder. In his telling, the only reasons to stay in India were family, a failed visa, or "devout patriotism".

What he says about AI founders is true. But it is true of almost any country when it comes to frontier technology (barring China, for reasons we don't need to go into here). A British, French, or Brazilian founder feels exactly the same pull toward the US.

What I doubt is that the debate is as charged anywhere else. In India, it quickly takes on moral terms, and it can go in two opposite directions. One lens is ambition. If you are smart you leave, and anyone who stays is doing so for sentimental reasons or because they couldn't make it. The other is nationalism. Why would you leave, rather than stay and do something for your country? I don't find either very useful, and both barely scratch the surface of how complicated the decision to move is, for the people making it and for the country they leave.

A 1946 law allowed just 100 Indian immigrants a year to the US; in 1960 there were only 12,000 India-born people

WE HAVE ALWAYS MOVED

India has the largest diaspora in the world—about 18.5 million in 2024, according to UN data. As a share of the population, though, that is only about 1.3%. Of 95 countries with more than 10 million people, India ranks 81st on the share of its people living abroad. At the top of that list are mostly countries people are fleeing, such as Syria and Ukraine, or poorer neighbours of rich ones, such as Romania and Mexico. The slice of India that Deedy is talking about is smaller still. About 3.2 million India-born people live in the US, or roughly one Indian in 460.

Still, moving abroad is nothing new for Indians, despite the old taboo against crossing the kala paani. When a young Gandhi sailed for England in 1888, the head of his caste declared him an outcaste. He went anyway. Merchants built trading networks across the Indian Ocean, empire shipped indentured labourers to Fiji and Trinidad, and the men who led our national movement studied and worked abroad. After independence, emigration happened in pockets: Punjabi workers to the foundries and mills of post-war Britain and doctors to the NHS, and from the 1970s workers from Kerala to the Gulf. Creating a new nation does unleash a certain ambition in its people, and building dams, steel plants, IITs and a space programme kept some of the brightest Indians at home.

America then was barely open. A 1946 law allowed just 100 Indian immigrants a year, and when the US census counted its India-born population in 1960, it found only about 12,000 people in the whole country. That changed in 1965, when the US ended the national-origin quotas that had all but shut out Asians and began admitting skilled immigrants. In *The Other One Percent*, Sanjoy Chakravorty, Devesh Kapur and Nirvikar Singh call this first wave the Early Movers. Nearly half of them had, or later earned, graduate or professional degrees, many in medicine. Their relatives followed in the 1980s.

The authors explain how Indians in America have done so well through selection. They were filtered three times: first by a social hierarchy at home that largely restricted higher education to the better-off, then by an exam and fee system that narrowed the pool further, and finally by an American immigration system built to admit people who matched its high-end labour needs. Households headed by an Indian immigrant now have a median income of about $156,000.

WHAT CHANGED IN 1991

What really changed the game was 1991. It was a moment of real renewal that in hindsight is second only to 1947, but it was a different kind of renewal. It unleashed individual ambition far more than it revived any shared national project, and it arrived just as the world was globalising fast.

America's Immigration Act of 1990 created the H-1B visa, just as American companies were scrambling for programmers. The IT boom and then Y2K turned that into a flood of demand, and Indian IT firms built whole businesses on sending engineers to client sites in the US. At home, liberalisation eased controls on foreign exchange and travel, and private colleges multiplied the number of engineering graduates. Chakravorty, Kapur and Singh call the people who came after 1995 the IT generation. Unlike the waves before them—in which some pioneers went first and their relatives followed—they were picked one at a time, for their individual skills, by individual employers.

In 1960, Italy was the single largest source of immigrants in the US, with about 1.3 million people. There were just 12,000 or so Indians. By 2024, the India-born population had grown to 3.2 million, almost all of it after 1990. I think of this as a kind of relay. Each era of American immigration has had its dominant groups, which eventually stop coming and simply become American. Indians may well be next, either because India gets richer or because America closes the door.

LIBERALISATION'S CHILDREN

The opening up of America was matched by a change at home. The middle class that liberalisation created began to withdraw from public life. It moved its children to private schools, its parents to private hospitals and itself to gated colonies with their own generators and water tankers. Leaving the country was the last step of that withdrawal.

The middle class that liberalisation created began to withdraw from public life. Leaving India was the last step of that withdrawal

Ruchi Gupta of the Future of India Foundation has a useful way of putting this. After liberalisation, she argues, the national project narrowed to individual economic aspiration, and people began to measure their own lives against the most visible lifestyles in India and abroad. Social media makes the comparison worse, because it presents exceptional success as ordinary life. Deedy's thread is a good example: a list of exceptional outcomes offered as the normal path for anyone smart.

It also explains where the two moral framings I started with come from. When the national project was a collective one, leaving looked like desertion. Once the project became individual advancement measured against a global benchmark, moving to where that benchmark lives became the fullest way of meeting it.

That is why America dominates how we talk about emigration, even though most Indians who leave go to the Gulf. The UAE alone has as many Indian emigrants as the US. But the money and the status run the other way. The US is now the single largest source of remittances to India. And the faces of Indian success abroad, from Sundar Pichai to Satya Nadella, are Indian Americans. We don't celebrate MA Yusuff Ali, whose LuLu Group runs hundreds of hypermarkets and malls across the Gulf, in the same way. The Gulf is still seen to offer wages, while America offers the American dream.

WHERE FROM HERE?

Here is the irony. India is much better off than it was in 1991, and yet more people want to leave. A lot of that is because prosperity has not kept pace with aspiration, or with the jobs and daily life that people now expect. Our corporate working culture is exhausting, and daily life in our cities is hard. It's hard to begrudge anyone wanting to leave that.

In some ways the bigger loss for the country is not that someone who wants to be the next Sundar Pichai leaves for California. The top 1% of the 1% gravitate to the best opportunities, and this is true of any country. The sad thing is that a driver, a plumber, or an electrician cannot get the dignity of decent, steady work at home. The engineer in Seattle and the electrician in Riyadh are responding to the same failure, even if they are rungs apart.

And the American door is starting to close. US law caps employment-based green cards that go to any one country at 7% a year, so Indians face queues that can stretch for decades. This year, the US hit its annual cap on one category of green cards for Indians in May, and a $100,000 fee on new H-1B visas is tied up in the courts. At home, the 1991 reforms have largely run their course, and the next round has never arrived with anything like the same force.

I don't think leaving is the proof of ambition that Deedy's thread makes it out to be, and I don't think it is a betrayal either. It is a decision people make based on what is on offer at home, and what is on offer can change. Right now it is not changing fast enough. When people ask me why I came back, I find the question a little jarring. I have moved a great deal since I first went abroad to study, and I have learned a lot in every place I have lived. I would like an Indian to be able to do what a British professional takes for granted: to go, come back and perhaps to go again, without each move being read as a verdict on the country or on the person making it.

Vedica Kant is a consultant and author. Views are personal

ILLUSTRATION: ZAHID

India Has the Most People Living Abroad...

People born in each country and living abroad (mn), 2024



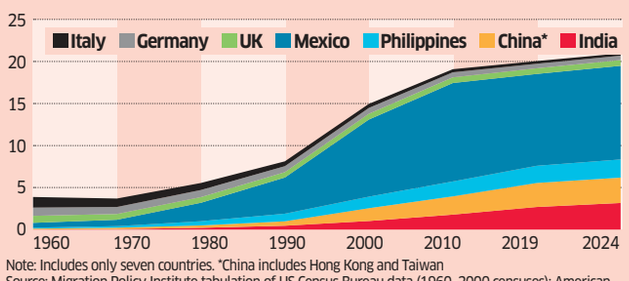
Source: UN DESA, International Migrant Stock 2024

...But Only 1.3% Indians Live Abroad

Rank	Emigrants as a share of home population, 2024	
1	Syria	36.2%
2	Venezuela	29.3%
3	South Sudan	26.5%
4	Ukraine	25.8%
5	Romania	24.1%
6	Afghanistan	17.7%
7	Haiti	17.1%
8	Cuba	17.1%
9	Portugal	16.8%
10	Dominican Republic	16.8%
81	India	1.3%
88	China	0.8%

Source: UN DESA, International Migrant Stock 2024; World Bank population 2024; Author's calculations
Note: These are top 10 of 95 countries with 10 mn+ people, plus India and China for comparison

Immigrants in US by Country of Birth (mn), 1960-2024



Note: Includes only seven countries. *China includes Hong Kong and Taiwan
Source: Migration Policy Institute tabulation of US Census Bureau data (1960–2000 censuses); American Community Survey 2010, 2019, 2024

GRAPHICS: VIJAY

Clarity is the Hottest Currency in Dating

To most adults reeling from the psychological waterboarding that is modern dating, a straight question and answer is almost erotic

Sonali Kokra

A few weeks ago, over a plate of burrata he had ordered without asking about my feelings about the coagulated lump of lactose-induced misery, a gent I was on a first date with sombrely told me he was "emotionally unavailable at the moment". He said it with the poise of a mixologist describing his signature drink—an exquisitely balanced interplay of ruefulness, a suggestion of self-awareness, the faintest whisper of past trauma, a delicate infusion of melancholy and a judicious splash of therapy-speak, finished with a flourish of reform just waiting around the corner.

"Let's see where this goes" is the most expensive and cheapest sentence in courtship

I thanked him for the information and his honesty, asked for the bill and went home.

He texted the next morning in a tone of wounded incredulity. Did I really not want to see where things might go "if we vibe"? I replied with the collective weariness of women who have had this particular conversation 17 times before breakfast: I did know where things would go. He'd told me, very plainly, for which I was rather grateful, never mind the 23 minutes I'd spent scrubbing the kajal off my eyelids for a date that had lasted a little under 22 minutes. He appeared to feel I'd been too literal, as though literalness was a failure of imagination on the part of the listener and not the only rational, sane response to being spoken to.

THE BEAUTIFUL DISCLAIMER

In my 20s, a man's emotional unavailability might have landed like an invitation to conquest on my thirsty-for-validation millennial ears. Now, it lands like the oppressiveness of trying to get the IRCTC website to load during tatkal hours. You already know it's an exercise in futility, and yet you are forced to refresh aggressively. I knew (and women know) what he was doing. The disclaimer is a legal instrument, a prophylactic against accountability. Issue it on night one and everything that follows can be filed under "But I never lied to you". Never mind the daily texts and calls, the weekend trip and the introduction to friends. The woman who stays has accepted the terms. The woman who leaves is being unreasonable. The whole scheme depends on his listener being too hopeful, or too emotionally invested, to take him at his word instead of taking her business elsewhere.

I call his type the Beautiful Disclaimer. It is the defining romantic figure of our age—fluent in himself, committed to nothing, and available in every gender.

Somewhere along the way, words lost most of their meaning. "Let's catch up" no longer buys a coffee. "I'll call you" does not guarantee a call. "Let's see where this goes" is simultaneously the most expensive and cheapest sentence in courtship because it can promise everything while committing the speaker to nothing beyond the next text. Courtship now borrows the language of action, but dispenses with the pesky obligation of following through. "We should go to Bali sometime" looks like a blueprint but behaves like a whim. "Let's definitely do this again" could be a booking for a next date or a cowardly goodbye. Nobody can hold you to either, which is why they get said.



IMAGE: AI-GENERATED

Evasion has gone clinical. "I'm working on my avoidant attachment" is the new "It's not you, it's me". Flakiness has rebranded itself as personal development. I have told you I can't be relied upon, so whatever I do to you is your responsibility. Sartre called this bad faith. The habit of treating your character like weather—something that merely happens to you and to everyone standing near you. A man who can recite his attachment style and still cancel on Friday has not done the work; he has done the reading. Knowing why you behave badly changes nothing until you stop. And insights that don't alter behaviour are… podcasts.

Vagueness profits whoever needs less. The man who describes himself as "pretty chill" has not discovered serenity. He has figured out that you will do the interpreting. Mr Big, patron saint of the arrangement, communicated chiefly by gazing out of penthouse windows in *Sex and the City*, while Carrie supplied the column, the endless analysis, the girlfriends' focus groups and the macabre spectacle of watching someone unravel. She did the labour. He was credited with depth. Occasionally silence is depth. More often it is a man without two original thoughts to rub against each other if his life depended on it.

The unsaid has been endlessly romanticised in fiction, and with good reason. If people simply said what they mean and meant what they said on, say, page 12, there would be no novel to sigh and swoon over. Which is how Sally Rooney's *Normal People* extracts hundreds of brilliant pages from two people who cannot manage one, and why it is magnificent. But even Jane Austen, who lived on delay, ended *Persuasion* with a sentence. After eight years of sulking, Captain Wentworth puts it in a letter to Anne: You pierce my soul. It's one of my favourite lines in literary romance. Mostly because it ends the suspense. (The bar was low in 1817. Men have since found a way under it.) But a delicious, drawn-out unwinding in a book costs the reader an evening. In life it costs three years, and no one needs (or wants) the sequel. In real life, watching fully grown adults perform their love lives as serials, episode after episode of 'hey stranger,' the finale perpetually postponed, is unsettling, not romantic.

The man who says, "Thursday at eight", and is outside my door at 7:55 pm will always win over an enigmatic mess

THE BURRATA MAN VS THE 7:55 GUY

Plain speech is also a luxury, and it is worth asking who can afford it. To say "I want this; do you?" you must be able to survive the mortification of being told "no". Most of us (but especially the women) were raised adept in the art of the hint. To ask directly is vulgar. And so we intuit, imply, infer and interpret. The log kya kahenge doctrine ensures no one has the temerity to want things out loud. Hinting is what people do when they cannot afford rejection. People who can, ask. To most adults reeling from the psychological waterboarding that is modern dating, a straight question (and answer) is almost erotic. It signals to the listener that here is someone whose life is sturdy enough to intentionally spend some of it on me and still absorb my loss without a juvenile three-day sulk. What's hotter than that?

Clear intentions, articulated well, cost a few seconds of nerve and sound wonderful. The same intentions honoured for 11 consecutive weeks cost something real. And that's what a character is. Nietzsche calls us humans animals that have the right to make promises. You must be recognisably the same person on Thursday as you were on Monday. The man who says, "Thursday at eight", and is outside my door at 7:55 pm will always win over the enigmatic mess who never apologises for or even explains his volatility. Because one hands you a future in miniature (sturdy and solid) and the other enlists you in an unpaid internship to build an imaginary person from scraps. He's sensitive (went quiet), complex (didn't call when he said he would), and inscrutable (said precious little, with great consistency). Clarity demolishes this myth of your own making. Real people arrive with real preferences and annoying eccentricities. Like over-quoting Sorkin while watching Sorkin. Take them anyway. Potential has never once shown up on time, let alone five minutes early.

Burrata Man, for the record, resurfaced a fortnight later. He had soul-searched while at the top of some mountain. He was now, he believed, "available-ish". His declaration arrived while I was at dinner with a man who told me after a week of talking that he liked me, wanted to see me on Sunday and hoped I didn't mind his saying it so plainly. I did not mind. He arrived at 7:55.

Sonali Kokra is a Mumbai-based writer. Views are personal

Miller Takes Over as Trump's Chief of Staff to Drive America First Agenda

Trump's longtime adviser and architect of his hard-line immigration policies takes charge as the White House braces for a Democratic-controlled Congress

AP

Washington: President Donald Trump said that Stephen Miller was replacing Susie Wiles as White House chief of staff, installing as his closest adviser a loyal, combative bulldog for his "America First" agenda as the president prepares to stare down a newly empowered Democratic Congress next year.

Miller, long a member of Trump's tight inner circle, is a key architect of the administration's hard-line immigration policies. He is one of Trump's longest-serving aides, joining his long-shot 2016 presidential campaign as a speechwriter. He most recently has served as White House deputy chief of staff for policy and oversees a broad portfolio, though he is best known for his role in Trump's immigration policy.

The staff shuffle signals that Trump, whose Republican Party was handed monumental defeats in Tuesday's midterm elections, is resisting a conciliatory approach to Democratic lawmakers who are eager to investigate the administration — including Miller himself as a top target. Miller,



Stephen Miller

41, is a dogged defender of Trump and has built a deep and sophisticated understanding of a president's executive power and how the federal government operates, portending a potential burst of executive actions in the final two years of Trump's presidency.

Wiles gave Trump her resignation Thursday night, a person familiar with the events told The Associated Press, speaking on condition of anonymity to describe the private conversation. Trump praised Wiles and said she'd continue to work for his political organisation.

Trump on Friday night denied that he made the change because he was unhappy with his team after the deep losses his party suffered.

"Not because of the election. It's just time," Trump said. "Sometimes you change. The election wasn't my election. I wasn't on the ballot."

Wiles, the steely political operator and longtime adviser to Trump, was the first woman to ever serve in that post and the longest-serving White House chief of staff for Trump, who cycled through four of them during his first four-year term.

"Serving President Trump in the White House has been the honor of a lifetime. I'm so proud to have been a part of what we've accomplished together from securing our border and cutting taxes to strengthening our economy and putting America First," Wiles said in a social media post shortly after Trump's announcement.

The departure also came months after Wiles indicated she no longer showed evidence of breast cancer after she underwent months of treatment for the disease, a diagnosis she went public with in March 2026.

Core Growth Market

▸▸ From Page 1

Jubilant Bhartia Group company Jubilant FoodWorks Ltd operates quick service restaurant chain Domino's Pizza in India as the latter's exclusive franchise rights operator.

The consolidation is widely seen as a development aimed at unlocking significant synergies between the two Jubilant entities. Jubilant FoodWorks' rivals Devyani International and Sapphire Foods are merging to bring together KFC and Pizza Hut under Devyani International, which will jointly operate more than 3,000 stores, intensifying competition in the sector. Varun Beverages and Devyani International are units of RJ Corp, helmed by Ravi Jaipuria.

India is a core growth market for Coca-Cola and among the Atlanta-based beverage maker's five largest globally. Coca-Cola India leads the country's ₹60,000 crore packaged beverages market and has an operating footprint of 14 manufacturing plants, along with eight copack units. The rest of Coca-Cola's bottling is handled by multiple independent bottlers.

In July, HCCB named Hemant Rupani as chief executive officer, succeeding Juan Pablo Rodriguez. Rupani was formerly Mondelez's president for Southeast Asia.

ET was first to report January 15 that Coca-Cola had tapped investment bankers for the proposed IPO to raise $1 billion, at a valuation of $10 billion.

Emotional Connect

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Sameer Seth, founder of Hunger Inc Hospitality that helped popularise contemporary mithai through its Bombay Sweet Shop chain, attributes the category's appeal to consumers' exposure to different cuisines, ingredients and formats, alongside their continuing emotional connection with Indian sweets. Its Diwali range includes pista khubani barfi, gulab orange roll and coffee hazelnut peda with assorted boxes starting at ₹695.

"It gives people a new way to enjoy something deeply familiar, while making mithai relevant to a wider range of occasions and audiences," says Seth. For instance, its dark chocolate kaju katli appeals across generations, he says.

Demand spans sweets for home, gifts for family and friends, and corporate hampers. The categories overlap: customers may discover a product themselves before returning to buy it for someone else, says Seth. Access has widened, too. Bombay Sweet Shop sells through seven Mumbai stores, its website and delivery platforms, including Blinkit.

The experiments are on. At Dzurt, chef Tejasvi Chandela's Jaipur-based patisserie, has introduced chocolate bars inspired by kaju katli, rose gulkand, saffron kulfi and pistachio Jaipur kunafa, the last incorporating Jaipur's traditional fini. Individual customers and corporate gifting are driving demand for the new collection, though Chandela says it is too early to assess year-on-year growth.

The decisions begin well before a festive launch, with chefs testing whether a new format preserves what customers value in the original. "When choosing what to experiment with, I look at whether the flavour has a distinct identity and whether the new format genuinely adds something to the experience," says Chandela. "Not every traditional sweet needs to be reinvented." Besides chocolate, Dzurt's ghevar and boondi tarts do well. Chandela says there's an appetite for familiar Indian flavours in unexpected formats.

At Sage & Saffron, Aditi Dugar's Mumbai-based boutique catering service, the Diwali mithai box has mithai biscuits that combine dry-fruit lauj, fruit gels and butter cookies. Flavours include pistachio, raspberry and rose, and hazelnut, coffee and orange.

Mountain Ecosystems

▸▸ From Page 1

Developed countries have argued that this runs counter to the agreement made at COP30, which was held in the Brazilian city.

In the aftermath of devastating floods, Nepal and Bhutan have proposed a discussion on the 1.5 degrees Celsius target and what it means for mountainous countries.

Nepal's minister for agriculture, forests and environment Gita Chaudhury pointed to the rapid warming of the Hindu-Kush Himalaya and other high mountain regions and stressed the need for "equitable access to climate finance and support for loss and damage" in her letter forwarding the submission. The proposal has called for a dedicated work programme on mountain ecosystems and integrating mountain-specific priorities into adaptation frameworks, climate finance arrangements and loss and damage mechanisms.

The other issue that has been raised for formal inclusion is trade and climate, with a reference to unilateral trade and protectionist measures being adopted in the name of climate action. The proposal made by the African countries argues that these measures shift the burden of decarbonising the economy on to developing countries.

Wide Range of Offerings

▸▸ From Page 1

Cult for Corporates, the enterprise wellness arm of Cult.fit says companies increasingly want managed facilities with certified trainers, safety checks and a variety of classes. Demand for on-site gyms is strongest at large technology campuses, manufacturing hubs and other workplaces where nearby fitness options are limited, said Arjit Shukla, head of business (enterprise) at Cult for Corporates.

"Domestic Indian enterprises and conglomerates now account for more than a quarter of our enterprise volume. The primary demand is for a fully managed, end-to-end operational stack," Shukla told ET. Employers are also broadening their offerings to include strength training, yoga and dance fitness, as well as fitness assessments and nutrition guidance, he said.

Gym membership provider Fit.Zone says corporate enquiries for employee memberships have risen about 15% from last year. Demand, once concentrated among large companies, is now coming from mid-sized businesses and startups as well.

"Companies approaching us mostly ask for a combination of access to gyms and fitness studios, group classes, access across multiple locations or cities, fitness assessments and personal training," said Arvindkumar D Porwal, CEO of Fitzone Technologies. IT and technology companies and global capability centres account for most of its enquiries, alongside companies in BFSI, consulting and startups. The partnerships are evolving, too. Providers are bundling gym access with app-based classes, personal training, fitness challenges and participation reports for HR teams. Companies, meanwhile, are using step challenges, running events, yoga sessions and sports tournaments to encourage participation.

India Inc is also building on these partnerships with fitness initiatives of its own.

At P&G, employees have access to an office gym, sports facilities at manufacturing sites, fitness and physiotherapy reimbursements, and an annual well-being programme that includes health checks and specialist consultations.

"Our people are our most valued asset, and their wellbeing is central to how we design work and shape our culture," said Robin Thadathil, CHRO of Procter & Gamble India.

InMobi offers employees fully equipped campus gyms and personal trainers, subsidised access to Cult.fit and HealthifyMe, and employee-led yoga and Zumba sessions.

"We recognise that well-being is deeply personal, so we focus on providing a rich, accessible ecosystem rather than a one-size-fits-all prescription," said Shefali Rai, CHRO of InMobi and Glance.

Walmart Global Tech India offers associates an annual fitness reimbursement of ₹25,000, alongside sports rooms, wellness events and on-campus activities.

Hefty Sums for Speed, Exclusivity

▸▸ From Page 1

The firm sourced the watch within two weeks. On another occasion, an Hermès bag requested in the morning was delivered by the afternoon.

The sums involved can be substantial. The average value of a sourcing request ranges from $300,000 to $500,000, according to concierge firms. Clients often pay hefty premiums for exclusivity and speed. For sought-after Birkins and watches, premiums can be two to three times the usual price, and even higher for particularly rare timepieces.

The final price can vary depending on the year of manufacture and condition. Sometimes even preowned but barely used pieces can command a premium. The business model is built around access. Premium concierge firms typically operate on a membership-fee structure, with additional charges for sourcing items through networks of collectors, specialist dealers and other intermediaries. For clients, the value lies not merely in finding an object but also in establishing its availability, authenticity and provenance. The more elusive the item, the more valuable these connections become. For this clientele, waiting is rarely part of the equation. "Such customers do not want to wait around and are happy to pay a premium to get what they want," Riddhi Banerjee, founder of luxury concierge firm Lunar Tales, said.

Banerjee recalled a particularly unusual request for a brand new 25cm Himalaya Birkin – one of Hermès' most coveted and ultra-exclusive creations – in its original boxed condition.

The firm tapped its network of collectors to source the bag. Sourcing rare watches can be equally demanding. One of Lunar Tales' notable acquisitions was an FP Journe rose-gold timepiece, limited to just 60 pieces worldwide and valued at £1.2 million. Sourcing is only one part of the challenge in such transactions; authentication and provenance are equally critical. Lunar Tales uses Entrupy, an authentication technology for the luxury resale market. As cross-border luxury consumption grows, a new generation of wealthy Indian buyers is becoming increasingly knowledgeable about rare collectibles. Japan has emerged as a preferred sourcing destination for its trusted pre-owned luxury market, while the US remains another major hub. Auction houses, specialist resellers and private collector networks form the backbone of this trade.

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Extract of Consolidated Unaudited Financial Results for the Quarter & Half Year ended 30th September, 2026.

	Particulars	Quarter Ended		Half Year Ended	
		30.09.2026 (Unaudited)	30.09.2025 (Unaudited)	30.09.2026 (Unaudited)	30.09.2025 (Unaudited)
1.	Total income from operations				
2.	Net Profit for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)				
3.	Net Profit for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)				
4.	Net Profit for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)				
5.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period				
6.	Equity Share Capital				
7.	Earnings Per Share (of Rs.5/- each) in Rs.				
	1. Basic:				
	2. Diluted:				

Note:

1 The above is an extract of the detailed format of Unaudited Consolidated Financial Results for the quarter and half year ended 30th September, 2026 filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Unaudited Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results for the quarter and half year ended 30th September, 2026 are available on the websites of the Stock Exchange(s) i.e NSE at www.nseindia.com and BSE at www.bseindia.com and the Company's website www.surya.co.in.

2 The Key Standalone Financial Information is as under:

(₹ in Lakhs)

	Particulars	Quarter Ended		Half Year Ended	
		30.09.2026 (Unaudited)	30.09.2025 (Unaudited)	30.09.2026 (Unaudited)	30.09.2025 (Unaudited)
1	Total income from operations				
2	Profit before tax				
3	Profit after tax				

SURYA ROSHNI LIMITED

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Website: www.surya.co.in, **Email-Id:** investorgrievances@surya.in

Scan to view Results

For Surya Roshni Limited
SD/
Vinay Surya
Managing Director
DIN: 00515803
New Delhi, November 7th , 2026

PVC PIPES & WATER TANKS | WATER PUMPS | CONSUMER DURABLES | WIRES & CABLES | CONSUMER LIGHTING

'We'll Live Happily Ever After, We Have Retirement Funds, & Bifocals'

Indian popular entertainment mirrors an India that's culturally attuned to seeing our parents and grandparents merely as extensions of ourselves, rather than complete people with their own dreams, sex drives...

FILM FATALE



ANNA MM VETTICAD

Jeanie and James lie in bed in each other's arms, catching their breath after a night of what one assumes was breathless sex. 'We're like Romeo and Juliet,' she says, gazing dreamily into the distance. 'Except we're old. And we're gonna live happily ever after. And we have retirement funds. And bifocals.'

Clearly, Jeanie and James are not your conventional romantic screen pair. They're a couple of seniors who go on a blind date and marry 6 weeks later in the new US streaming series Newlyweds. With the charismatic 60-year-old Téa Leoni and 70-year-old Tim Daly playing the leads, backed by writing shorn of ageist condescension, the result — in the episodes dropped so far — is a sweet, lighthearted show.

Watching Jeanie and James got me wondering for the zillionth time why so few Indian films and series are romantic relationship sagas of people past 60, played by actors past 60. Hema Malini was in her 50s when she starred with Amitabh Bachchan in 2003 in Baghban (Hindi), which is usually cited in this context. Exceptions like Pookkaalam (Malayalam) in 2023, with Vijayaraghavan and KPAC Leela, are precisely that — exceptions.

A major reason why such films are uncommon is that most veteran male stars who remain popular as leads in Indian commercial cinema avoid playing characters of their actual age. Bachchan is a rarity who changed tracks in 2000, after a decade of missteps, and found adventurous, talented writer-directors.

For the rest, the fear of being perceived as senior citizens extends to an aversion to romances with women their age. This is among multiple factors that contribute to the lower average longevity of female stars, who are forced to shift to supporting roles and being character artistes much earlier. This, in turn, means that scriptwriters tend not to conceptualise romances with specific veteran female stars in mind, since producers are unlikely to greenlight them.



DO YOU REALISE, I DON'T NEED A PREGNANCY TEST!

The combined effect of these circumstances is that credible autumnal romances are hard to come by. This leads to a self-perpetuating drought such that even if a male actor in his 60s, 70s, 80s or above wants to consistently play characters his age, the choice of scripts is limited.

But there is more to this situation than the insecurities of India's male superstars, and ageist attitudes towards women. After all, Hollywood, the international film industry that Indians follow most closely, is no paradise for women, as female stars have testified in interviews over time. Yet, Hollywood churns out a steady stream, even if not a deluge, of films and shows — across genres, including romances — revolving around seniors, including women.

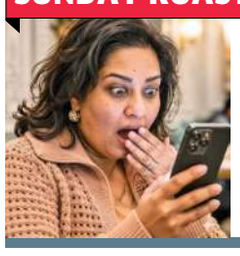
Jeanie and James in Newlyweds (left) are a couple of seniors who go on a blind date and marry 6 weeks later

Sample the following from just the past decade: Meryl Streep's entire filmography; Grace and Frankie in which Jane Fonda and Lily Tomlin play seniors whose lives are up-ended when their respective husbands fall in love with each other; the romantic drama, Our Souls At Night, featuring Fonda and Robert Redford; Hacks, starring the septuagenarian Jean Smart as a comedy queen; the legal series, The Good Fight, headlined by the now-septuagenarian Christine Baranski; A Man On The Inside, led by Ted Danson, who is nearing 80.

Indian popular entertainment, on the other hand, mirrors an India that's socially and culturally attuned to viewing our parents and grandparents merely as extensions of ourselves, rather than complete people in their own right with dreams, sex drives, and career plans. It appears that the 4 ashramas (stages) of life as prescribed in Hindu scriptures — brahmacharya, grihastha, vanaprastha, and sanyas — are so deeply ingrained in our collective psyche across religious communities, that the resultant mindset governs the country's film and TV industries.

When your head is geared towards seeing Mom and Dad, Grandma and Granddad, solely as retirees, counsellors and babysitters to your babies, it's hard to picture them like Jeanie and James, wrapped in each other's arms after breathless sex. Wait…what?! Mom and Dad had sex?!!! [*she asks and faints*]

SUNDAY ROAST



RESHOM MAJUMDAR

Can we not b so txtually depraved, pls?

Spare us the gory details about the state you're in when texting

London: I called a friend and got a text back: 'In the loo.'

'Too much detail,' I replied, squirming a little under my own skin. She was some 8,000 miles away. There was no immediate threat to me. And yet, somehow, I felt I had intruded. 'I'll call you back' would have done. A perfectly serviceable sentence, discreet enough to cover everything from a board meeting to a bowel movement.

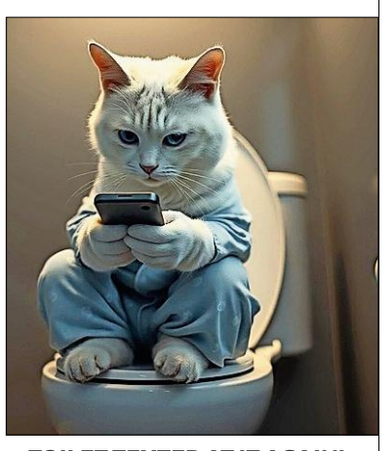
Naturally, I went looking for data. A 2024 survey commissioned by telephone-answering company Face for Business found that 1 in 6 British phone owners admitted to having answered a call on the toilet. May I withdraw from several conversations I was suspicious about in the past!

I've also been told that office calls taken on mute may be conducted from the loo. This remains unverified. But it has put a rather different complexion on: 'Let's sit down and discuss this.'

How many times have I been earnestly explaining something while the person at the other end was engaged in a far more pressing matter? And when they said, 'Sorry, you're breaking up,' was I? Somewhere along the way, we seem to have confused being available with providing a running commentary. 'Can't talk now' is not a lie. It is a small curtain drawn across your private life. Please leave it closed.

We need some texting manners. A little restraint. If I send you a message, you do not have to reply before I've put the phone down. Equally, if you haven't replied for 20 minutes, I must resist sending '???'.

Video calls have only complicated matters. What is the dress code for being professionally present in your own home? Does the whole body have to attend, or just the parts on the payroll?



TOILET TEXTER AT IT AGAIN!

I am prepared to accept a smart shirt over pyjama bottoms. The upper half has targets. The lower half has given up. This seems an honest reflection of working life. But anyone attending a meeting without trousers must accept that retrieving a charger could become a career decision.

Of course, people have always read in the loo. The newspaper is practically a bathroom accessory. But it has boundaries. It does not vibrate — yet. It does not tell you your boss was typing. Nobody can ring *through* the crossword and say, 'Have you got a minute?'

You take the newspaper in to get away from people. You take the phone in and bring 43 of them with you. There you sit with your colleagues, your cousins, the school WhatsApp group and a woman demonstrating how to fold a fitted sheet. It is an extraordinary number of guests for a small downstairs toilet.

And the phone is never finished. There is always another message, another video, another notification suggesting something has happened which, on inspection, has not. You went in to check one text. You emerge knowing how to grout a patio, (particularly useful if you live in the West), what your cousin had for lunch, and that someone you last met in 1998 is 'feeling blessed'.

The newspaper, at least, has a last page. The phone has a charger.

I miss the modest mystery of being unavailable. You rang someone. They weren't there. Perhaps they were out. Perhaps they were in the bath. Perhaps they had looked at the ringing telephone and decided they had suffered enough for one day. You were left to cope with this uncertainty.

Now, if a call goes unanswered, there must be a text explaining why, preferably sent during the very activity that prevented the call.

I don't need to know where you are every moment of the day. I just need to believe you're wearing trousers, a kilt perhaps, or a sari. Even a sarong would do.

THE BIG SLEEP, A DIWALI EYE-CLOSER

For someone who thinks sleeping is for losers, a 24-hr Kumbhakarnian stretch can be a magnificent snooze-fest

RED HERRING



INDRAJIT HAZRA

Today, I plan to sleep the whole day and night. You may ask me how I plan to do that, considering it's Diwali. Let's just say I have the will and the skill, and above all the desire, to sleep the whole day and night.

Apart from disbelief, I can sense vapours of Narayana Murthyian disgust rising from many of you. 'How can you *waste* a festive day like this?' which actually hides your real horror: 'How can you sleep so much?' As if I shall personally be bringing down the country's GDP by 0.8675% by being utterly unproductive in body and spirit this Diwali.

Our modern relationship with sleep is delicate. Much care is taken to not just getting the right amount of sleep, but also the right quality. People forego partaking of the ultimate hot chocolate — reading long op-ed columns — but are wide-eyed about ketamine-induced glutamatergic mechanisms, Mann ki Baat episodes, herbal tea, sleeping apps that play sounds of crickets rubbing their legs next to a gurgling stream with a pashmina fluttering in a breeze that once touched Sri Devi…

I come from the 'sleeping is for losers' school of circadian rhythm. In an ideal world, we would not *need* to sleep — or go to the toilet. But then, we live in a world where body-clocking people love Taylor Swift and Ed Sheeran.

A 26-author May 2026 Nature study, 'Sleep chart of biological ageing clocks in middle and late life,' tells me that the optimal amount of sleep is 6.5-7.8 hrs for women and 6.4-7.7 hrs for men. Not counting Friday and Saturday nights, and days of high excitation, I usually clock 6 hours of sleep these days. But I desire to sleep more. Badly. Every day.

One of my heroes, Kumbhakarna, uncle to my namesake, has been, disgracefully, turned into an epitome of somnolence, lethargy, and uselessness. And yet, Kumbha-Chacha was a great warrior and formidable scholar, telling off his brother Ravana — certainly far more forcefully than JD Vance has told off Donald Trump about his war on Iran being cause for recent heartburn — of both the moral wrongness and political stupidness of kidnapping a fellow king's wife. ('Couldn't you have picked a peasant's?!')

This Kumbhakarna, according to Valmiki's Ramayan, was duped into cursing *himself* to sleep 9 years at a stretch each sleep cycle, after Saraswati (on Indra's instructions) tricked her Lankan devotee into seeking 'nidravatvam' (sleep), instead of 'nirdevatam' (annihilation of the gods). It's like Nitin Nabin — he's BJP president, just saying, not to be confused with the late actor Navin Nischol — asking for a Congress-mukt Bharat, and instead getting an angrez-mukt Bharat, which he already had anyway.

The Lankan was tricked into seeking 'nidravatvam' (sleep), instead of 'nirdevatam' (annihilation of the gods)

WAKE ME UP WHEN NOVEMBER ENDS: FROM 'MEWAR RAMAYAN,' SAHIB DIN, C. 1650

'Oversleep', like 'over-drink', retains that terrible reputation as a 'curse'. But like resisting the shower and then once in, not wanting to come out, sleep becomes gorgeous once you're asleep. Even a wake (as opposed to woke) person like me understands its gorgeousity. Oversleep, as opposed to sleep, needs to be devilified from its 'bad cholesterol' vibes.

There's a song tucked away in the Beatles' magnificent 1966 album, Revolver, 'I'm Only Sleeping.' John's voice, the song's pace, guitar strum, and Paul's dum-dee-dum tiptoeing bass together act like Kaa's hypno-disc eyes in Disney's 1967 animation film version of The Jungle Book. 'Please, don't wake me,/ No, don't shake me/ Leave me where I am,/ I'm only sleeping,' is John's genuine imploration.

But it's the bridge, with Paul joining in on harmony — 'Keeping an eye/ On the world going by my window/ Taking my time/ Lying there and staring at the ceiling/ Waiting for/ A sleepy feeling…'–followed by

George's backward lead guitar track that slips out and in like a smoke, which lulls the insomniac null and happy void.

The French have a name for orgasm: *petite mort*, or little death. I'd venture forth to call sleep, *grande orgasme*. Or as 19th c. poet Gerard Manley Hopkins, in 'No Worst, There is None,' wrote with pebble perfection, '…all/ Life death does end and each day dies with sleep.'

Raise a pillow to Lord Kumbhakarna this Diwali. Off I go to sleep.

indrajit.hazra@timesofindia.com

All is Fair in Books and Coffee at Frankfurt

At the world's largest trade book fair, you're a traveller through 'countries'

INFERNAL BUSINESS



ABHIJIT GUPTA

AI and its discontents hung like a fug inside the 5 giant halls that housed this year's Frankfurter Buchmesse (Frankfurt Book Fair), now in the 78th year of its modern avatar. This was, of course, unavoidable, given the unease in the publishing industry over the increasing presence of machine intelligence in sectors of the book trade thought to be AI-proof.

But there were other causes of unease as well. The number of trade visitors at the world's largest trade fair for books last month had fallen by 2,000 from the previous year's tally of 2,38,000. Exhibitors, too, nearly fell by 10% from the 4,350 in 2025.

Blame it on geopolitics, fair watchers said. Two years ago, when I had first visited the fair, the Russia-Ukraine war had been going on for two-and-a-half years. It was depressing to find the spectre of the war still shuffling about 2 years on. Then, as well as now, the fair organisers had invited many Ukrainian publishers, authors, and journalists. They were there this year as well. But many had taken body blows. The first publisher who I had a meeting with had lost nearly 8 mn books after a drone hit their warehouse in August.

Most of my meetings were in Hall 3, where most of the European and Latin American publishers had their stalls. After the Philippines last year, Czechia was this year's guest of honour.

It was amusing to see the motto of the Czech pavilion, 'A Country on the Coast', a hat-tip to a certain Mr William Shakespeare who generously allowed a coastline to Bohemia in his play The Winter's Tale. Bohemia, part of today's Czechia, famously does not border on the sea. I was hoping that there would be other in-jokes of a Kafkaesque nature — Kafka on the Shore? — or, at least, a man in a Good Soldier Švejk costume, from the hero (sic) of Jaroslav Hašek's 1921-23 eponymous multi-volume novel — tramping about. But no.

It was also a good occasion to make friends with Chile, the guest of honour in 2027. The press I look after had recently brought rights to two Chilean collections of short stories. So our stock with the Andean nation was good, which at Frankfurt usually translates into free coffee.

For itinerant trade visitors like me, the quest for free coffee is a major motivator. By evening, the problem becomes one of plenty, as most national stalls host wine receptions, and it is possible to drink and nibble one's way from, say, Portugal to Estonia. The Indian stall is made of sterner stuff, and traffics in nothing more exciting than masala chai and samosas.

There are many who argue that post-Covid, rights fairs have become a bit of a white elephant, since one can as easily deal with other publishers and agents online, at virtually no cost. While this might be the case for publishers from the 'global north', 'south-south' conversations are much more likely to happen in places such as Frankfurt. In 2024 and 2026, my chief takeaway from the fair was the opportunity to meet small and independent publishers from Latin America, Africa, the Arab world, and Asia.

This year, the invitee theme was comics and graphic novels, and I was delighted to be able to meet a bunch of young, talented, and supremely innovative comic book publishers and creators from countries as diverse as Uruguay, Vietnam, Burkina Faso, Turkey, Egypt and Georgia. The possibility of translating a Vietnamese graphic novel — about the career of a young comic artist in Ho Chi Minh City — into, say, Bengali is an intriguing and challenging prospect.

The possibility of translating a Vietnamese graphic novel into Bengali is an intriguing, challenging prospect



COMIC RELIEF FOR SERIOUS PUBLISHERS

Equally pleasurable was the discovery of a book of French poetry exclusively on football, 90 poems standing for 90 minutes, spanning the victory of Les Bleus in 1998 to the heartbreak of 2022. What's not to like--unless you're a fan of Argentina, of course?

The writer is director, Jadavpur University Press

NO OFFENCE — *Morparia*



LET'S TALK ABOUT...

Diwali, The New Soft Power

Well, it was bound to happen…

Tell me, is talking to yourself a hobby or a passion?
Hmmm…it's a need. After all, only I can be interesting enough for myself.

Wow, modesty ain't your middle name. Now what were you murmuring about?
Global luxury has discovered Diwali. And no, we're not talking about a 'Happy Diwali' Instagram post. Bvlgari launched its first global Diwali campaign, 'Passing the Light', with an installation of 4,500 terracotta elements by Indian artist Doyel Joshi at the Jaipur Centre for Art. Jimmy Choo brought out five shoe styles and five bags in gold and rich red. Christian Louboutin's Rayon de Lumière, or Ray of Light — a capsule collection — offered festive sparkle. Ferragamo unveiled its first India-dedicated Diwali capsule, while Michael Kors and Valentino marked their fourth and third Diwali celebrations in India, respectively. Quite the guest list, no?



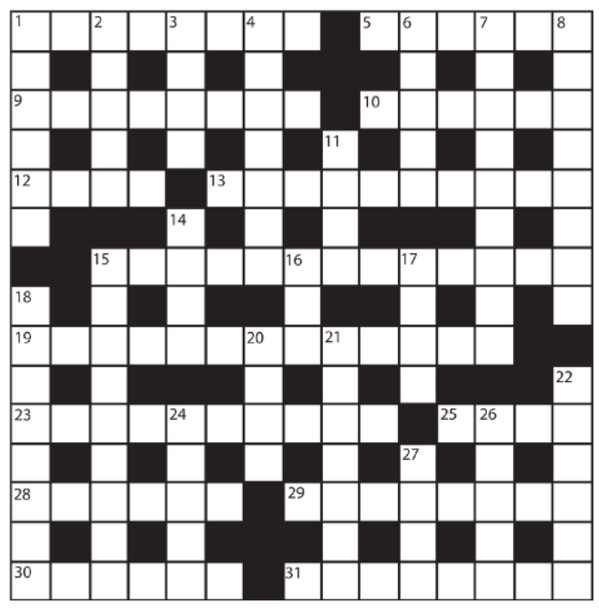
That's quite a start.
That's not all. Our desi designers are taking the party abroad. Gaurav Gupta celebrated Diwali with Harrods in London through a theatrical couture presentation inspired by the Ramayana. At Harrods, Diwali now sits alongside Christmas, Spring Festival, Ramadan and Eid on its cultural calendar. Meanwhile, Sabyasachi threw a Diwali reception at New York's Metropolitan Museum of Art. Not to mention that the Gram is full of Diwali bashes thrown by the diaspora.

So…you are saying that Diwali has arrived, culturally speaking that is?
The light's getting passed around. Ramadan and Lunar New Year are more established fixtures on global luxury calendars, but Diwali is finding its place. Of course, brands can't inmgnore the Indian customer any longer. And this festive economy is growing globally.

But a long way before we christen it 'India's next soft power'?
Yes, let's not prepare the victory speech just yet. A capsule collection and a party are not what makes it a cultural habit. But the lamp has been lit. It looks like it will be shining bright soon.

Text: Nupur Amarnath

ET Sunday Crossword 0193



ACROSS
1 Strong drinks accompanying writer's card game (3,5)
5 Plug opening appearance (6)
9 Tense worker skirts trouble in Asian country (8)
10 Try to secure current journal about male escort (6)
12 Test former partner in the morning (4)
13 Some music by composer, say, gives support to cyclist (10)
15 With training, ham can imitate a calculator (13)
19 Taking chances, left new units in charge after work (13)
23 Late cleric somehow related to current generation (10)
25 Film nearly broke (4)
28 I've ordered woman to withdraw capital (6)
29 Energetic person provided backing regarding dance (8)
30 Pay back judge and German (6)
31 Formidable setter's setting (8)

DOWN
1 Understand articles in Greek (6)
2 Antelope found in Kenya lately (5)
3 Unprepossessing guy wanders round lake (4)
4 Authorise crew to meet (7)
6 Remove crystals, using gadget Victor's thrown out (2-3)
7 Old guy, one in jail, upset one who's totally self-absorbed (9)
8 Handouts distributed, a large number (8)
11 At first I didn't entertain any thought (4)
14 Special seaman produces Polaris, for example (4)
15 Both sexes drink fizzy pale ale – it's revered in Vancouver (5,4)
16 Crew's servant (3)
17 Greek character turns up in conservatoire (4)
18 Second space vehicle stored energy as well (8)
20 1 in Paris and 9 in Rome operating system (4)
21 Soldiers interrupt mosque leader's poetic movement (7)
22 Disconnect a French listener bored by piano (6)
24 Nine musicians turned up in part of joint (5)
26 Brown stuff's what's needed to start vehicle, I'd say (5)
27 Woman's love for great man (4)

SOLUTION TO No 0193:
ACROSS: 1 Gin rummy. **5** Advent. **9** Thailand. **10** Gigolo. **12** Exam. **13** Handlebars. **15** Mathematician. **19** Opportunistic. **23** Electrical. **25** Skin. **28** Vienna. **29** Fireball. **30** Refund. **31** Imposing.
DOWN: 1 Gather. **2** Nyala. **3** Ugly. **4** Mandate. **6** De-ice. **7** Egomaniac. **8** Thousand. **11** Idea. **14** Star. **15** Maple leaf. **16** Man. **17** Iota. **18** Moreover. **20** Unix. **21** Imagism. **22** Unplug. **24** Tenon. **26** Khaki. **27** Hero.

©The Daily Mail

Have Some Care

India's caregiving sector is in a crisis—the demand is massive and growing, but the workforce remains poorly trained and paid, informally employed and frequently treated like domestic help

Lijee Philip



AI-GENERATED IMAGE

For Pratibha Khemesra, an octogenarian architect living in Bengaluru, the high points of her day are the phone calls from her children from two ends of the world. Her son is in Brisbane, her daughter in Oslo. Since they cannot be with her, they have employed two caregivers to look after her in shifts. They also monitor the CCTV footage of her home, to ensure her safety and comfort from thousands of kilometres away.

Yet the arrangement has brought its own anxieties. In the past year, the agency that provides caregivers has replaced four of them, including a 65-year-old driver who moved to caregiving after his reflexes deteriorated and driving became difficult. "The ground-level experience is pathetic," says Khemesra. "Many caregivers lack adequate training and are recruited merely to fill the gap."

(Names of care recipients, relatives and workers have been changed at their request.)

Khemesra is caught between two concerns. Alone with caregivers whom she barely knows, she worries about her safety. Her other worry is: What if they stop coming altogether? So she hesitates to complain even if they arrive late or fail to perform their duties properly.

Her children can afford the cost of care, which comes to ₹75,000-80,000 a month for both carers. Many families cannot.

The other side of the picture is grim too. Carers have to work long, demanding shifts for modest wages, with little respite or job security. An average caregiver earns ₹900-1,200 for a 12-hour shift, or around ₹27,000-36,000 a month, but agencies take a cut of 30-40%, which can even go up to 50%.

"When the middleman earns more reliably than the carer, supply will always be fragile," says Bhavana Issar, founder of Mumbai-based Caregiver Saathi. Agencies justify their share, saying they are providing training and operating on tight margins.

A carer's work is also physically and emotionally draining. In Mumbai, Sunita Raut, who was taking care of a dementia patient, says, "I had to be hypervigilant, but every time the patient would fall asleep, I was given household chores to do." The lack of breaks, exhausting commute and the patient's suspicious behaviour, including instances of physical and emotional aggression, took a toll on Raut's health. She said the agency did not adequately address her concerns about safety. After a year, she quit caregiving to start a sandwich stall.



"When the middleman earns more reliably than the carer, supply will always be fragile"
BHAVANA ISSAR, Founder, Caregiver Saathi, Mumbai

Khemesra and Raut reveal the magnitude of crisis at the heart of India's caregiving sector: the demand for caregivers is massive and growing, but the workforce is poorly trained and paid, informally employed and frequently treated like domestic help.

India's nursing shortage is well known. Less visible is its shortage of trained caregivers who help older adults and patients with disabilities or chronic illnesses. As families shrink, children migrate for work and women enter paid employment, the traditional arrangement of relatives, usually women, providing unpaid care is coming under strain. Paid care has developed recently through informal labour networks, brokers, nursing bureaus and small agencies with uneven standards of recruitment, training and supervision.

TRAINED ATTENDANTS

Issar says families often expect care attendants to be an extra pair of hands for both the household and the patient. Meanwhile, some carers struggle with basic monitoring, like checking blood pressure and blood glucose, while others are left to manage dementia-related behaviour without adequate training.

Pune-based Vidya Nair was alarmed when her elderly mother, who had dementia, grew unusually lethargic and spent long periods in bed. Tests raised concerns about medication overdose and possible effects on her liver. The family suspects the caregiver was administering sleeping tablets to make the woman easier to manage.

Tom George, founder of Guardian Angel Homecare in Kochi, says training is the panacea for the ills in the sector.

A doctor recently approached Guardian Angel Homecare about his 90-year-old father who is bedbound. He had been looked after by a well-meaning neighbour, who ended up feeding him heavy, unhealthy meals that made him listless, and hauled him between bed and wheelchair in a way that risked injuries to both. The son found it difficult to correct the elderly man who was known to the family for years.

A home nurse finally adjusted the nonagenarian's meals and demonstrated safer transfer techniques. Within three days, the man was sitting up and chatting with his family. "Training doesn't push family compassion aside; it gives that compassion the practical knowledge and safety it needs to work," says George.

He says fresh candidates at his agency undergo training at its Guardian Angel Institute of Caregiving. Its entry-level programmes costs ₹30,000, besides ₹10,000 for food and accommodation, for 18 days. Experienced caregivers are recruited directly after screening and skill tests, followed by a seven-day training programme.

These days, however, agencies find it difficult to retain trained workers. Like nurses, carers are flying to countries like Israel, UK, Germany and Japan where they get paid ₹2.5-4 lakh a month, although the work remains precarious in a foreign land.

GREY MATTERS

For India, the challenge in the caregiving sector is growing alongside its elderly population. India had about 149 million people aged 60 and above in 2022, projected to reach 347 million by 2050, according to UN Population Fund's India Ageing Report 2023. Population aged 80 and above is expected to grow by about 279% in this period.

According to an analysis of the Longitudinal Ageing Study in India (LASI) by NITI Aayog, 75% of the elderly have one or more chronic disease and 48% of older adults have limitation in at least one instrumental activity like managing medications or shopping.

Vaibhav Tewari, cofounder of home healthcare provider Portea Medical, estimates that 20-25 million older people would require caregiving by 2050, including those with severe dependency, dementia and post-surgical or palliative needs. Portea has trained more than 50,000 caregivers over the past 12 years. Tewari says supply "needs to be augmented on a war footing" to meet demand over the next two decades.

Industry estimates cited by NITI Aayog put India's care market at $29.6 billion in 2023, projected to reach $72.3 billion by 2030. The opportunity is there. The workforce to realise it is not.

COST OF CARE

For Pallavi Joshi, a bank employee in Gurgaon, the need for care arrived alongside a personal tragedy. After her husband died in a car accident, she was left to support herself while caring for her 75-year-old mother-in-law who required palliative and post-hospitalisation care. She returned to work to pay off her home loan while her savings went into care. A caregiver for a 12-hour daily shift cost her ₹25,000 a month.

Joshi's experience illustrates the financial burden on households that need assistance for months or years. Round-the-clock care is expensive, while live-in assignments for patients with advanced dementia, nighttime wakefulness and heavy physical dependency are difficult to fill and retain.

The Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship and the National Council for Vocational Education and Training have developed qualifications to establish benchmarks across the care sector, but no action is visible on the ground. Training programmes and certified assessors remain a distant dream. "The endeavour is to make credible training accessible across India, backed by structured career progression opportunities for young aspirants," says Mona Gupta, CEO of Delhi-based nonprofit Home Management and Care Givers Sector Skill Council.

Supply of caregivers needs to be augmented on a war footing to meet the numbers projected in the next 20 years"
VAIBHAV TEWARI, Cofounder, Portea Medical



The employment model needs to change. The low social status attached to the job is the biggest barrier. Workers placed through informal intermediaries often have no written contracts, paid leave, insurance, or grievance mechanism.

The consequences extend beyond the care sector. Lack of affordable carers forces working women to turn down promotions, cut down working hours, or leave employment altogether to care for parents or parents-in-law. Employers lose experienced workers and incur replacement costs, yet few offer structured caregiver support or homecare benefits.

JOB TO PROFESSION

The government is waking up to the problems of a greying country. The Union Budget 2026-27 announced an initiative to train 150,000 multi-skilled caregivers in a year. A national registry, transparent recruitment, written employment terms, reasonable hours and grievance mechanisms would further protect workers and families. Meanwhile, the Keralam Senior Citizens' (Care and Protection of Rights) Bill, 2026, proposes a phased expansion of certified caregivers in agencies—25% by the second year, 60% by the third and 100% by the fourth.

Tewari argues that caregiving needs a recognised career ladder, allowing workers to progress from caregiver to senior caregiver, field supervisor and care coordinator. Specialisations in dementia, palliative care and post-acute recovery could create opportunities for higher wages and greater responsibility.

NITI Aayog has also identified the potential for India to become a global hub for skilled caregivers amid a projected worldwide shortage of 11 million health and care workers by 2030. India and Japan have agreed on a plan to facilitate the movement of 50,000 skilled Indian workers over five years, with caregiving among priority areas.

India's caregiving challenge is not merely a shortage of people willing to provide care. It is the absence of a sufficiently organised, affordable, professionally supported and accountable care system"
Dr ARVIND MATHUR, President, Caregivers Asha Society, Jodhpur



India needs a national caregiving framework to set standards, protect workers and give families confidence in the care they receive"
TOM GEORGE, Founder, Guardian Angel Homecare, Kochi



But India needs them back home too. Better wages, safer working conditions and professional recognition are essential to retain them.

Arvind Mathur, president of Caregivers Asha Society, Jodhpur, says, "India's caregiving challenge is not merely a shortage of people willing to provide care. It is the absence of a sufficiently organised, affordable, professionally supported and accountable care system." Mathur says professional recognition does not mean turning every caregiver into a nurse. It means acknowledging that safe personal care requires specific knowledge, skills and responsibility, backed by competency-based training, supervision and decent working conditions.

India's challenge is no longer the number of carers. It is whether caregiving can become a profession that workers want to enter, families can afford and vulnerable people can trust.

Khemesra's children can arrange shifts and monitor cameras from far away. What they cannot remotely guarantee is the quality of care their mother receives. Closing that gap will be one of the defining tests of India's ageing future.

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'India Needs a New Social Contract for Elderly Care'

India's ageing population is putting its traditional model of family-led care under strain. Nuclear families, migration and longer life expectancy are creating an urgent need for trained caregivers, community support and new models of elderly living. The answer lies in reimagining the entire ecosystem of care, says Rohini Nilekani, chairperson of Rohini Nilekani Philanthropies, in a conversation with Lijee Philip. Edited excerpts:



AI-GENERATED IMAGE

India's traditional model of elderly care, centred on children and families, is under strain. Are we ready to accept that children cannot be the default caregivers anymore?

We have to make a complete societal transition along with our demographic transition. Earlier, it was assumed that the family and community would take care of the elderly. But with nuclear families and working couples, it is increasingly difficult to expect families to shoulder this responsibility alone.

We should not put too much guilt on children who may be living abroad or in different cities and cannot physically look after their parents. All four of my parents lived and died under my care, and I was fortunate to be able to do that. But today, at 67, I do not expect my children to do the same for me. If they do, it will be a bonus, but if they don't, I will understand.

The family will remain important, but it cannot be the only answer. We need a new social contract in which communities, the state and the market also take responsibility.

If families cannot do it all, can communities become the missing link, particularly in addressing loneliness and mental well-being?

We are already seeing healthier older people helping those who need assistance. Some are experimenting with living together, sharing activities and building new social bonds. We need to encourage these forms of community and intergenerational connections.

I particularly like the Friendship Bench project pioneered by Dr Dixon Chibanda in Zimbabwe. It is a community-led initiative in which trained older women sit on benches in neighbourhood parks and offer a listening ear to people dealing with loneliness, anxiety, or depression. They are trained to recognise signs of mental distress and help people access appropriate support.

I think we can create our own version in India, harnessing the empathy, experience and wisdom of older women and men to support other senior citizens. We tend to see older people only as recipients of care. But they can also be caregivers, mentors and contributors.



"The Friendship Bench project in Zimbabwe is a community-led initiative in which trained older women sit on benches in neighbourhood parks and offer a listening ear to people dealing with loneliness, anxiety, or depression. I think we can create our own version in India"

India faces a serious shortage of trained caregivers. How do we transform caregiving from an undervalued domestic work into a recognised profession?

We need to communicate the dignity of this work and, equally importantly, the dignity of the people who do it. A caregiver is not a servant. This is someone you depend on, often at your most vulnerable.

All four of my parents initially found it difficult to accept that someone else would look after them. But over time, they developed close relationships with their caregivers. I remember Suman, who looked after my mother. My mother was initially reluctant to have anyone around, but within 15 days, Suman had become more important to her than I was!

There was a bond of mutual respect and comfort. We need to tell more such stories, including those from caregivers' perspectives. They must be recognised for the emotional support and companionship they provide, not just the physical work. They also need better training, professional recognition and protection of their rights.

Can technology help bridge India's caregiving deficit? What else must change to ensure older people can age with dignity and independence?

We cannot train 10 million caregivers overnight. This is where technology, particularly AI, can help accelerate training and build skills. We need positive use cases for AI that address India's unique challenges, with appropriate safeguards. But we must be technology-enabled, not technology-led.

We also need public infrastructure that allows older people to retain their independence—good footpaths, wheelchair access, parks and public spaces where they can meet others and maintain social connections. These do not necessarily require massive budgets. They require a shift in priorities.

We must also move away from the assumption that older people are necessarily dependent. Many have decades of experience and still want to contribute to society and the economy. We need to harness that experience. Ultimately, we have to design our cities and society for an ageing population, so that growing older does not mean losing one's independence, dignity or sense of purpose.

Attention Please

A guide to reclaiming your focus

The handy little device in your pocket may have made life easier, but studies say that it has reduced our attention spans to that of a goldfish. **Glynda Alves** speaks to experts on how to stay focused in a world of distractions

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If you're reading this in print, congratulations: Your attention span has made it this far. But the urge to check a notification, switch tabs or scroll through a reel can be hard to resist. The result? Stillness feels uncomfortable. The problem may not be that we're losing our ability to focus, but that we're training ourselves to seek distraction.

As Rod Mitchell, clinical director of Emotions Therapy Calgary, puts it, "Each escape trains your brain to quit when things get hard." Psychologists and neuropsychologists say attention is shaped by habit, not fixed capacity. So the same brain that learns to crave stimulation can also reclaim its attention span. Here's where you start...

Continuous switching, hopping from one platform to another, splinters our attention. It makes it difficult to maintain our concentration or focus

"A worn-down attention span is usually out of practice rather than broken."
– Rod Mitchell, clinical director, Emotions Therapy Calgary

"When we mindlessly scroll through short-form content, over time, this preference for quick stimulation/ gratification becomes more challenging."
– Ankita Gayen, clinical psychologist, MPower Centre, Kolkata

ARE YOU IN THE DANGER ZONE?

Take this quiz to know where your attention span is at

1. HOW LONG CAN YOU READ BEFORE CHECKING YOUR PHONE?
A. Less than 5 minutes
B. 5-15 minutes
C. 15-30 minutes
D. More than 30 minutes

2. CAN YOU WATCH A 90-MINUTE FILM WITHOUT LOOKING AT ANOTHER SCREEN?
A. Never
B. Rarely
C. Sometimes
D. Almost always

3. HOW OFTEN DO YOU SWITCH TABS WHILE WORKING?
A. Every few minutes
B. Several times an hour
C. Occasionally
D. Only when necessary

4. DO YOU REACH FOR YOUR PHONE DURING PAUSES IN CONVERSATION?
A. Almost always
B. Often
C. Sometimes
D. Rarely or never

5. CAN YOU SIT THROUGH A MEAL WITHOUT CHECKING NOTIFICATIONS?
A. No, I check constantly
B. Only if I make a conscious effort
C. Usually
D. Easily





YOUR RESULTS

Mostly As: The restless scroller
Your attention is compromised. Even a quiet moment can feel like an invitation to check your phone. Try creating small pockets of screen-free time and see how long you can stay with one thing.

Mostly Bs: The distracted multi-tasker
You can focus, but notifications and the urge to switch tasks often get in the way. A little structure – silencing alerts or keeping your phone out of reach – could help.

Mostly Cs: The mindful switcher
You have a reasonably steady attention span, though the occasional notification or impulse can break your flow. However, there's room to make it more intentional.

Mostly Ds: The focused observer
You seem comfortable giving your attention to one thing at a time. Congrats, you can stop reading now.

DON'T LET YOUR BRAIN QUIT



"Focus is attention you steer; distraction is attention that gets taken," says Mitchell. He answers the questions that need 'attention'...



WHAT DESTROYS OUR ATTENTION?
Reaching for your phone in every small gap, and the other is switching tasks the moment work gets uncomfortable or difficult. "Each escape trains your brain to quit when things get hard."

THE FIRST SIGNS OUR ATTENTION IS BEING DIMINISHED?
Small pauses start to feel unbearable. You catch yourself picking up your phone during an ad break, involuntarily. The more obvious signs are trouble finishing a long article.

YOUR ATTENTION IS SLIPPING
- Small pauses feel unbearable. You need stimulation at all times.
- You reach for your phone on autopilot at any point.
- You switch tasks when work gets hard. WhatsApp or email becomes an easy escape.
- You struggle to finish longer reads – even long articles.
- You keep checking for a hit. Likes, messages or videos pull you back.

When every email expects a reply within minutes, the inbox becomes an easy escape whenever work gets hard. Work with your team on reply times, and protect one email-free day

SHOCK AND BORE

People tend to treat their phone as an instant escape or a dopamine hit. Dopamine is often misunderstood as the pleasure neurotransmitter. It's less about pleasure and more about anticipation and reinforcement. It's the motivation neurotransmitter. You think: Maybe there's something on my phone that will make me feel better. Like a rigged slot machine, we keep checking Instagram for likes, WhatsApp for connection or YouTube for videos. And your brain starts rewarding that unpredictability. Over time, the buzz of the phone — or even a moment of boredom — becomes the trigger. Instead of sitting with the boredom, we automatically reach for the phone, almost on autopilot.

In a 2014 study led by psychologist Timothy Wilson at the University of Virginia, US, researchers found that many people would rather self-administer a mild electric shock than sit alone in an empty room with their own thoughts, shares Dr Shraddha Shah, clinical neuropsychologist, Jaslok Hospital & Research Centre, Mumbai.

START SMALL

Ankita Gayen, clinical psychologist, MPower Centre, Kolkata, says that our lives have become centred around "short, crisp and instantly rewarding experiences", which makes it harder for us to sit still. Switching between WhatsApp, Instagram, email, work and other tasks adds to this. Gayen explains that when we constantly switch between different tasks, we repeatedly, by ourselves, interrupt our attention before it can become fully engaged with one activity. In a way, we condition ourselves to respond to distractions.



WHAT WORKS?
Gayen suggests activities like reading a book, taking a walk minus the phone or simply allowing yourself to be bored. Her advice? Start small with just 15 minutes and small, achievable goals. The trick is to make the task feel doable rather than overwhelming and ambitious. So, read for 15 minutes first and gradually increase the duration by five minutes. "Consistency matters more than intensity when building a habit," she adds.

QUICK FIXES

1. Wait out the itch. When tempted to grab your phone, acknowledge the urge ("there's the itch") and stick with the task for another minute. Gradually stretch it to two, then five.
2. Book a focus appointment. Tackle one task at the same time and place daily set cues for your brain to settle. Start with 10 minutes, adding five after every three distraction-free sessions.
3. Leave one gap empty. Pick a daily wait, like a commute or the minutes before a meeting, and spend part of it without your phone. Start with two minutes, add a minute each week.

CHANGE IS COMING

One can see changes almost within days. The itch to check your phone tends to ease within days, and a longer attention span often follows within two to three weeks. But even after a few weeks of practice nothing is changing, see a doctor. It can be sleep issues, low mood, or undiagnosed ADHD.



BE MINDFUL

Short-form content has trained the brain to expect constant novelty. Every time we fill a pause in our daily routine with a scroll, we reinforce the idea that stillness is a problem. But the brain can be taught resilience. Researchers have shown that even 14 to 15 days of changed phone habits can measurably improve attention skills.



Pharma Heirs Trade Safe Bets for Scientific Ambition

MORE THAN FAMILY BUSINESS A host of drug cos are making expensive, long-term strategic shifts just as the next generation steps in to take on larger roles

Shilpa Ranipeta

Hyderabad: There is change in the air in India's family-run drugmakers. The companies built by first-generation entrepreneurs are entering businesses with longer timelines, deeper scientific requirements and a starkly different set of risks.

Laurus Labs' contract development and manufacturing revenue rose 36% in 2025-26 as it expanded capacity. Granules India is investing in complex generics and peptide manufacturing. Bharat Biotech is looking beyond vaccines to advanced therapeutics.

All of these moves coincide with the next generation taking on larger roles at these companies.

How much of the shift is being driven by the successors, and how much reflects the wider industry's move into more complex businesses, remain an open question. Either way, the companies are committing capital to areas with longer timelines and uncertain returns.

For the next generation — the heirs to India's pharma legacy — the test will be whether they can build the capabilities, make the right long-term bets and turn those investments into sustainable engines of growth, while creating value for investors.

EVOLVING PLAYBOOK

Companies such as Sun Pharma, Torrent Pharma, Laurus Labs and Granules India have seen the second-generation step into leadership roles in the recent past, taking over and growing significant segments of the business, and changing not just the businesses they pursue but also how they are run.

Bhanu Prakash Kalmath, partner and healthcare and pharma industry leader at Grant Thornton Bharat, sees this as part of a broader shift. "The industry itself is looking at how to move up the value chain from generics to complex molecules, large molecules, novel biologics and biosimilars," he said.

For three decades, Bharat Biotech focused primarily on developing infectious disease vaccines. The Covid-19 pandemic put this business model through an unprecedented test, requiring the company to create a critical vaccine indigenously in just a few months. Now, it wants to move into advanced therapeutics.

Raches Ella, director at Bharat Biotech, sees himself as both a continuation and a departure from his parents Suchitra and Krishna Ella. The company's risk appetite has not changed dramatically, but the problems are changing, according to him. "What I'm trying to add is that second engine of deep-tech innovation, trying to address more complex diseases, such as oncology, autoimmunity and metabolic diseases," he told **ET**.



In a way, the industry's renewed focus is emblematic of the transition from Indian pharma's traditional pillars of low-cost, large-scale manufacturing of established products toward specialised segments.

INCREASING COMPLEXITY

The shift is visible across companies. At Laurus Labs, the next phase, now being overseen by founder Satyanarayana Chava's children Soumya and Krishna, is being built around CDMO (contract development and manufacturing organisation), fermentation, peptides and advanced technologies, while the company is also reworking its generics business.

At Granules India, the focus is shifting towards complex generics, differentiated products and peptide CDMO, steered by chairman Krishna Prasad Chigurupati's daughter, Priyanka.

At Sun Pharma, Aalok and Vishi Shanghvi, children of Dilip Shanghvi, have taken on prominent roles in the company. Aalok, who became chief operating officer in 2025, oversees emerging markets, global generic R&D, generic business development, operations and APIs.

The move-up the value chain requires deep technical, scientific capabilities and risk-taking abilities, according to Kalmath. "As the complexity of these businesses increases, the skills required to run them also need strengthening. If companies are moving into areas such as large molecules, they need to bring in deeper and more specialised capabilities, whether from India or from international markets," he said.

BUILDING TEAMS

That reality may be changing the role of the family member helming the business, with the next generation building teams around specialised capabilities.

Krishna Chava, director at Laurus Labs, said his three-and-a-half-year tenure at Dr Reddy's Laboratories provided invaluable insight into managing a business without the advantages of being the founder's son. He has integrated this philosophy into Laurus Labs, ensuring that the CDMO division is driven by a team rather than relying solely on executive leadership.

Priyanka Chigurupati is taking a similar approach at Granules India. "I can't be the one doing all the work. We have a team; my job is to build the team and build the people who can help us drive the vision and even enable the vision," she said.

At Bharat Biotech, Raches Ella is transitioning from hands-on scientific research to strategic leadership, directing the company's scientific and financial resources.

That matters more when the bets have become larger. Laurus Labs, for instance, incurred capital expenditure of ₹4,300 crore between 2021-22 and 2025-26 and is stepping up investment in fermentation, peptides, and gene therapy and antibody-drug conjugate infrastructure. Granules India reported capex of ₹555 crore for 2025-26 as it expanded capacity and built out its complex-generics and peptide platforms.

A LONG-TERM SHIFT

Returns on these investments, however, will not show up in the next quarterly results.

"I think my proof, my ultimate validation will be 20, 30 years ahead of me," said Raches Ella.

What the next-gen do have is a distinct approach to risk.

The founders built their companies by taking instinctive risks. Founder Satyanarayana Chava said the next generation is more calculated in how they approach risk.

It relies heavily on data, according to Soumya. "We definitely look at data more now. We compare markets, evaluate numbers, and technology has made that process more precise," she said.

Granules India executive director Priyanka Chigurupati said she has put in place a more formal way of deciding where resources go. "Something as simple as a stage-gating process in portfolio strategy, we didn't have it earlier. Now we incorporate all those aspects," she said. "Products are now categorised and resources allocated across those categories rather than being pursued more randomly."

At Torrent Pharma, chairman Samir Mehta's son, Aman, is pushing for an acquisition-led growth strategy, with the aim of moving the company to among India's top three pharma players.

In a June 2025 interview with **ET**, he said acquisitions would remain a priority in India, while international expansion would follow a more measured approach. "Our goal as the next-gen is to maximise percentage of right calls versus wrong," he told **ET** in April this year. It clearly is a time of big bets, big shifts, and long waits in India's pharma landscape.

Prices of 137 Cancer Drugs to Come Down from Monday

Press Trust of India

New Delhi: Prices of 137 anti-cancer drugs from various brands will be significantly reduced from November 9, following the government's decision to cap trade margins, resulting in an estimated annual savings of ₹3,502.31 crore for consumers.

According to an official release by the Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilisers, the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) capped trade margins on 137 anti-cancer medicines.

This followed recommendations made on October 17 by an expert committee constituted under the Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS).

Around 10-15 identified drugs not yet launched in India will also fall under Trade Margin Rationalisation (TMR) upon release

So far, 76 pharmaceutical companies have submitted revised maximum retail prices (MRPs) for 1,225 formulations covering 121 drugs. Price reductions have been reported across 1,031 formulations, with 600 brands reporting cuts exceeding 50% and the steepest decline reaching 96.45%, the release stated.

Around 10-15 identified drugs not yet launched in India will also fall under Trade Margin Rationalisation (TMR) upon release.

The revisions lead to massive reductions in several vital cancer treatments. For instance, breast cancer capsule Palbopro (Palbociclib 125 mg) by RPG Life Sciences has dropped from ₹40,421.33 to ₹2,720.

Prostate cancer tablet Abirone (Abiraterone acetate 250 mg) by Arvincare Pharma has been slashed from ₹41,250 to ₹3,218.23.

Lung and cervical cancer injection Bryxta (Bevacizumab 100 mg) by Zydus Lifesciences is down from ₹25,995 to ₹3,318, and Reliance Life Sciences' DenOsteoRel (Denosumab 60 mg) dropped from ₹24,955 to ₹6,240.

Breast cancer injection Lupiher 2 (Pertuzumab 420 mg) by Lupin will now cost ₹37,358.30 against its earlier MRP of ₹83,520.

'Liquid Biopsy can Significantly Ease Financial Burden for Cancer Patients'

ET Q&A **CATHERINE ALIX-PANABIERES & KLAUS PANTEL** Scientists

Liquid biopsy, a non-invasive blood test used to detect, monitor and analyse cancers, is steadily gaining acceptance as a standard tool to assess progression and treatment in a range of cancers. Scientists **Catherine Alix-Panabieres** and **Klaus Pantel**, who coined the term "liquid biopsy" in 2010, were in Mumbai recently to meet top oncologists and unveil an indigenously developed liquid biopsy platform by Actorius Innovations. Alix-Panabieres is director, Laboratory of Rare Human Circulating Cells, University Medical Centre of Montpellier, France, and Pantel is director, Institute of Tumour Biology, University Medical Centre Hamburg-Eppendorf, Germany. They spoke with **ET's Vikas Dandekar** on the growing adoption of liquid biopsy in detecting circulating tumour cells in clinical practice. Edited excerpts:

How did you strike the term liquid biopsy?

Klaus Pantel: In tumour diagnosis, the routine method is to take a needle and put it into a solid tumour mass and that is called solid biopsy. How then to frame a word when we draw a blood sample or any other body fluid? So, we came up with the name liquid biopsy. We thought people may think it's stupid. The famous science journal Nature mentioned it as one of the key discoveries of the last 20 years, and they quoted us as the mother and father of this term, liquid biopsy, in 2010.

How much have cancer treatments gained from the new method?

Catherine Alix-Panabieres: First nobody believed in detecting circulating tumour cells in the blood because it's really a rare event, mostly seen in early stages or minimal residual disease state. It was not easy to prove that cell fragments from the tumours exist in blood. Then it was good to stimulate the scientific community to work on liquid biopsy analysis. The definition now is broad because we talk about circulating biomarkers derived from tumour cells. That means tumour cells release some specific information like DNA, RNA, EVs or extracellular vesicles and many others. These are not directly released by tumour cells, but induced like the immune system, speaking in the context of immunotherapy. It means that when you have a tumour cell, you must check what is the background of the host, and how the immunity is able to fight or counterbalance. Everybody would like to have such a test to personalise treatment or medicine and manage cancer patients. But we need to get more interventional clinical trials to prove the benefit for the patient and what clinicians can do to treat their patients better.



India has a rising cancer burden. Do you think using techniques to understand circulating tumour cells can lead to cost benefits?

Pantel: I think it will have a significant positive effect on the financial burden of the patients. First, if we detect cancer early, it can be cured and the patient can continue a normal life with a normal life expectancy. The patient can pay taxes and does not need any further treatment. I also think when we use the blood test to understand which patient needs which therapy, it is very important because then we do not use expensive therapies that do not work. We can just use expensive therapies for those patients on whom it works and that is also cost-effective. I would say that even if our test is $1,000, it would save probably $10,000 in therapy costs that are otherwise given in the wrong way. This has a strong economic impact as early detection and personalised cancer treatment will reduce costs.

If the benefits are so clear in terms of treatment and costs, why are circulating tumour cell tests and liquid biopsies not getting the due popularity?

Pantel: I guess if you want to develop a new field, it is always difficult. People who do imaging may not like our field. People that do pathology or tissue biopsy may be a bit afraid. If you come up as something new, the established fields get a little bit defensive. We need to create a new field with concerted efforts. In the European Liquid Biopsy Society, we say let's forget for one moment that we are competitors and what we have as a common goal. We want to develop a whole field and if this field is developed, which means if it's really used in the clinic, all of you will be happy. It's good to have this competition because it also drives technology advances.



E20 Petrol Samples Tested by State-run Oil Cos Meet Quality Norms: Oil Ministry

Press Trust of India

New Delhi: The government on Saturday defended the 20% ethanol-blended petrol programme, saying tests of 893 samples collected across 27 states and Union Territories, including 56 in Karnataka, found them compliant with prescribed quality standards, as state-run oil companies challenged the Karnataka government's claims of excessive ethanol content in fuel sold at some retail outlets.

The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, in a statement, said Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation (HPCL) had found ethanol content in all 893 samples within the prescribed 19-21% range under the Bureau of Indian Standards' IS 17021 specification.

The 56 samples tested in Karnataka, covering different locations and all three oil marketing companies (OMCs), recorded ethanol content of 19-20%, averaging 19.3%, the ministry said.

The findings directly contradict a recent press release by Karnataka's Department of Food, Civil Supplies, Consumer Affairs and Legal Metrology, which claimed that petrol samples collected from certain retail outlets in the state contained 26-31% ethanol.

IOC, BPCL and HPCL have questioned the sampling and testing procedures adopted in Karnataka's October 2026 exercise

The three OMCs have questioned the sampling and testing procedures adopted in Karnataka's October 2026 exercise, arguing that the reported results cannot be independently validated without compliance with prescribed statutory procedures and disclosure of the technical details of the tests.

The dispute comes at a time when India's nationwide E20 programme, aimed at reducing dependence on imported crude oil and lowering emissions, has come under scrutiny over concerns about vehicle mileage, engine compatibility and the potential cost to consumers.

Under the Motor Spirit and High Speed Diesel (Regulation of Supply, Distribution and Prevention of Malpractices) Order, 2005, read with the Marketing Discipline Guidelines (MDG) 2024, six one-litre samples must be drawn during an inspection. Two are handed to the dealer, two retained by the oil company or department, and two sent to an authorised laboratory.

OMCs said samples collected during a September exercise were routed through the State Level Coordinator to designated company laboratories, but the subsequent October exercise was reportedly conducted without their representatives.

Tata Steel Q2 Profit Jumps 16% on Strong India Performance

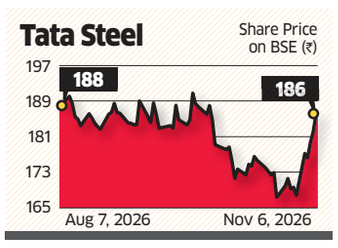
India operations drive earnings growth, offsetting weaker revenue in the Netherlands and the UK

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Tata Steel's consolidated profit rose 16% year-on-year to ₹3,700 crore in the September quarter, driven by strong performance in its India operations. Revenue in the Netherlands and UK operations declined from a year earlier.

The steelmaker also reported an exceptional gain of ₹349 crore during the quarter, compared with an exceptional loss of ₹420 crore in the year-ago period.

Tata Steel produced 8.07 million tonnes and sold 7.92 million tonnes of steel at the consolidated level during the quarter. Its India operations accounted for 6.18 million tonnes of production and 5.98 million tonnes of sales.



"India continued to be the cornerstone of our performance with volumes growing 16% QoQ despite a seasonally softer quarter, reflecting the strength of our market presence and customer reach," chief executive officer TV Narendran said.

Consolidated revenue rose 11.5% year-on-year to ₹65,436 crore, while earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortisation (ebitda) increased more than 17% to ₹10,665 crore. Ebitda per tonne of steel sold stood at ₹13,462, up from ₹11,518 a year earlier.

Revenue from India operations rose to ₹42,653 crore from ₹34,787 crore a year earlier. Ebitda per tonne increased to ₹17,790 from ₹15,580.

"In Netherlands, the successful restart of the direct sheet plant and its return to rated capacity has supported improvements in both the product mix and cost profile. In the UK, while the Llanwern pickle line is now fully operational, the market conditions continue to be influenced by elevated imports and inventory build-up across parts of the value chain," he said.

Revenue from the Netherlands operations declined to ₹15,330 crore from ₹15,719 crore. However, ebitda per tonne improved to ₹6,062 from ₹5,948 a year earlier.

In the UK, revenue fell to ₹5,275 crore from ₹5,927 crore. The ebitda loss per tonne widened to ₹19,027 from ₹13,510 a year earlier.

Tata Steel spent ₹3,280 crore on capital expenditure in the September quarter and ₹6,860 crore in the first half of the fiscal year.

Its consolidated net debt rose to ₹91,423 crore at the end of September from ₹84,173 crore a quarter earlier. The net-debt-to-ebitda ratio increased to 2.4 times from 2.3 times.

The company announced its results on Saturday. Its shares closed at ₹186 on the BSE on Friday, up 2.2% from the previous close.

NOEL TATA RETIREMENT

In line with Tata Group governance guidelines, Noel Tata will retire as non-executive, non-independent director and vice-chairman of Tata Steel's board with effect from November 11, at the close of business.

Wigmakers Have Bad Hair Days as Tirumala Tresses Get Dyed

Faith may endure, but quality of hair donated to the temple trust is seeing a change as natural black gives way to vivid hues

Shantanu Nandan Sharma

New Delhi: At the hilltop Tirumala temple in Andhra Pradesh, the changing colour of hair offered by devotees may be saying more about fashion than faith. The share of high-priced natural black hair — the most coveted category among wigmakers — in the hair donated has nearly halved over the past three years, even as dyed and grey hair have gained ground, an ET analysis of a dozen auction reports shows.

Wigmakers and researchers attribute the shift more to the growing trend of hair colouring among younger women than to declining religious fervour among millennials and Gen Z.

This one temple in Tirupati alone accounts for half of India's supply of Remy hair — the premium grade that makes the best wigs and hair extensions.

The share of natural black hair in the temple's auctions had fallen to 9% in September last year from 29% in July 2023, before recovering to 16% in the latest round in September this year, held by the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD).

The last auction saw 4,800 kg of natural black hair being bought under three length categories — 27 inches and more, 19–26 inches and 10–18 inches — compared with 25,100 kg of grey and dyed hair across the same categories.

The share of grey and coloured hair, meanwhile, has generally risen, albeit with some fluctuations, according to the analysis of TTD auction reports procured from participating hair exporters.

Some wigmakers attributed the fall in black hair collection to evolving trends in hair styling.

"If you go by the numbers alone, it would suggest that fewer young women are offering their hair at the temple. But that is unlikely to be the case," said a prominent Chennai-based wigmaker, requesting not to be named. "Our analysis shows that an increasing number of younger women, including those in villages and smaller towns, are colouring their hair. But once hair is chemically coloured, its quality for making the finest wig deteriorates." Two other hair exporters backed this view.

An email query sent to TTD remained unanswered.

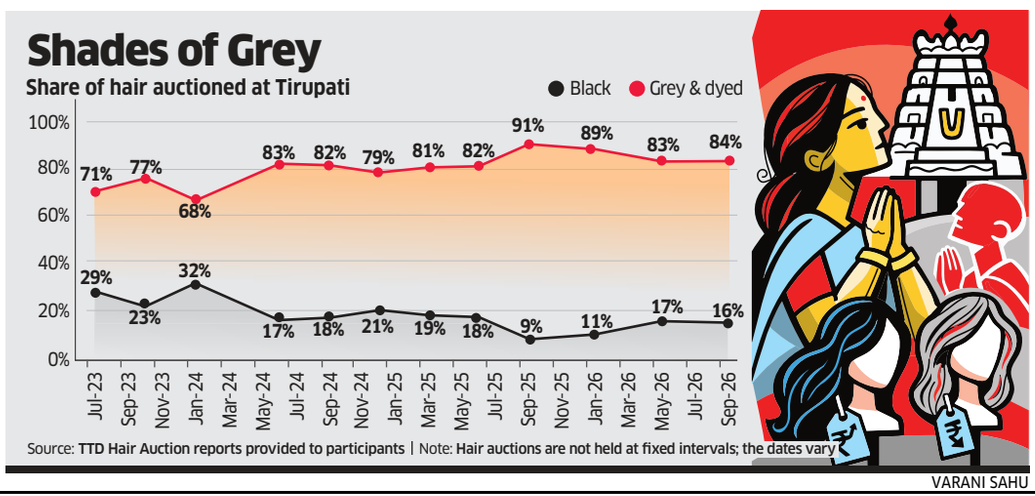
The premium commanded by natural black hair is reflected in the reserve prices set by the temple trust. In the latest auction, for example, hair measuring 27 inches and above was priced at ₹77,000 per kg, while the reserve price for lengths between 19 and 26 inches was ₹63,500 per kg. The corresponding prices for grey and coloured hair were ₹55,000 and ₹41,600, respectively. The rates underscore the premium exporters place on natural black hair.

Benjamin Cherian, president of the Human Hair and Hair Products Manufacturers' and Exporters' Association of India, said religious faith, particularly among India's middle-income groups, has remained entrenched. "If anything, faith is growing stronger. More devotees are visiting Tirumala for darshan. I don't see people giving up tonsuring anytime soon, nor do I foresee an existential crisis for the wig industry," he said.

Cherian, however, pointed out that the volume and category of hair put up for auction are entirely at the temple trust's discretion. "The trust has large godowns where it can store substantial quantities of hair. It releases stocks for auction depending on market demand and prevailing prices," he said.

The number of devotees tonsuring their heads has remained substantial. According to the trust's official data, 22,462 of the 65,467 devotees who visited the temple on November 6 shaved their heads. On some days, the number of devotees tonsuring their heads crosses even 50,000. But for wigmakers, the volume alone is of little consequence: short hair, particularly men's hair, commands very little value in the market.

P Bhaskar Reddy, a professor at Sri Venkateswara University, Tirupati, who specialises in cultural history and temple studies, said the decline in natural black hair does not necessarily signal a weakening of faith. The quantities offered, and at times the share of black hair, have naturally fluctuated since the post-Covid peak in 2023, he said.



VARANI SAHU

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economictimes.com

The Woman Who Broke Lennon's heart

Once Britain's highest-paid singer, Alma Cogan's life ended in obscurity, with the Beatles star at the centre of her final chapter

She was the most famous, best loved, highest-paid and the most spectacularly glamorous singer Britain had known. Yet, when she died tragically at the age of 34, she was already forgotten.

The bitter irony of Alma Cogan's life was that she was cast into the shadows by the man said to be her secret lover, John Lennon.



The dark-eyed, feisty daughter of an East End haberdasher, Cogan dominated British headlines, radio and television throughout the 1950s and early '60s, becoming one of the era's biggest female stars.

Dubbed "the girl with a giggle in her voice", she churned out records at a remarkable pace: In one year alone, she released 12 singles, two EPs and an album.

She headlined the London Palladium and the Royal Variety Performance, shared the stage with Judy Garland and starred in the first *Morecambe and Wise* TV series.

Fame brought wealth and lucrative endorsements. Her apartment became a celebrity hotspot, attracting guests such as Joan Collins, Terence Stamp, Elizabeth Taylor, Noel Coward, Princess Margaret, Cary Grant and Roger Moore.

But failure and obscurity were just around the corner.



Alma Cogan died of cancer at just 34

PICS: INSTAGRAM, FACEBOOK

FADING STAR

Between Cogan's golden year, 1958, and the Beatles's first chart entry, in 1962, popular music had undergone a dizzying transformation. Yet, Cogan remained firmly in the limelight, co-starring with The Beatles on ITV's *Sunday Night at the London Palladium* in 1964.

As a Liverpool art student, Lennon, eight years Cogan's junior, had mocked her clothes, hair and music. But after entering her high-society circle, he fell deeply in love with her — a relationship his then-wife Cynthia believed reflected his need for an older, maternal figure.

Though there is no evidence of an affair, Cynthia was convinced that there was. Ironically, Lennon would help end Cogan's career with their joint appearance on Britain's hottest TV show, *Ready Steady Go!* Introduced by Lennon, Cogan performed Patti Page's '*Tennessee Waltz*' in a sequinned dress, but the audience was unimpressed, and the song failed to make it to the charts.

BATTLING CANCER

Cogan retreated to a tour of northern clubs, but she had become ill and struggled to perform. Sweden remained her last devoted audience, but during a tour in the Scandinavian country, she collapsed and was diagnosed with ovarian cancer.

Cogan died unmarried and largely forgotten. Lennon is said to have wept. "Cogan died, and something odd happened to John," recalled Cynthia, adding that had she lived, Lennon would have not begun his relationship with Yoko Ono, who turned up in his life weeks after Cogan's death.

– Daily Mirror



PIC: AI GEENRATED

There's a war brewing between Hollywood and Silicon Valley, and it's the billionaire CEOs who are being cast as the bad guys

Silicon Villains

Ryan Zickgraf

In *Musk*, Alex Gibney's exhaustive documentary about the Tesla and SpaceX CEO, there's a lot of evidence against the world's richest person: Aggrieved ex-wives and partners, unfulfilled promises about self-driving cars, the hostile Twitter takeover, the slide into right-wing American politics — all narrated by a sinister-looking AI version of Elon Musk himself.

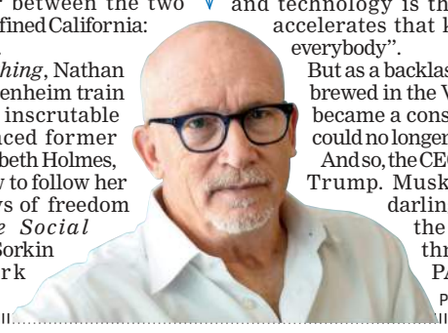
The documentary ends by turning Musk, who once compared himself to Iron Man, into a techie version of Thanos. In the final scene, Earth explodes, and a lone ship carrying Musk slips away towards Mars. "I would like to die on Mars, just not on impact," Musk says.

It's a line Musk has been using for more than a decade. Here, it becomes the punch line to the apocalypse.

TECH TREATMENT

Hollywood has found a fresh supply of super villains from Silicon Valley. *Musk* is only one of several recent movies that can only be described as 'techlash cinema' — a new front in a messy civil war between the two institutions that have defined California: Technology and movies.

In *You Can See Everything*, Nathan Fielder and Lance Oppenheim train their cameras on the inscrutable sphinx that is disgraced former Theranos founder Elizabeth Holmes, who invited a film crew to follow her during her last 34 days of freedom before prison. *The Social Reckoning* sees Aaron Sorkin returning to Mark Zuckerberg after his 2010 success, *The Social Network*. This Zuckerberg is played by Jeremy Strong as an emotionless automaton who is attempting to conceal Facebook's harmful impact on social-media-obsessed teens and American democracy itself. And in *Artificial*, Andrew Garfield plays Sam Altman, the sociopathic genius behind OpenAI.



PIC: GETTY IMAGES

CHANGING TIMES

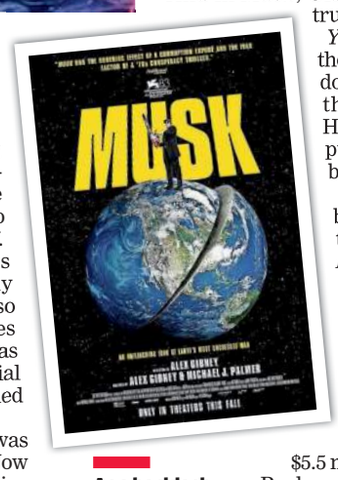
Not long ago, tech CEOs getting this treatment would've been unthinkable. Even as recently as 2016, Barack Obama was writing in tech magazine *Wired* that it was the best time in human history to be alive and that "science and technology is the warp drive that accelerates that kind of change for everybody".

But as a backlash against the bosses brewed in the Valley, the workforce became a constituency that CEOs could no longer control.

And so, the CEOs defected to Donald Trump. Musk — once a liberal darling — tried to deliver the election to Trump through his America PAC. The following year, the lords of Silicon Valley lined up at a White House dinner to praise the president, with Altman thanking Trump for being "such a pro-business, pro-innovation president" — the kind of compliment that used to be reserved for Obama himself.

Now, the creative class is striking back. This is partly because of politics, but it's also because they see AI companies such as OpenAI and Anthropic as heralding the old post-industrial nightmare, only this time aimed at the winners.

For decades, manufacturing was told their jobs were obsolete. Now many see de-skilling, automation and layoffs coming for the copywriter, the paralegal, the junior coder and the screenwriter. Hollywood's writers went on strike over AI in 2023. Techlash cinema represents the rebellion's culture war, something that was also witnessed in the midterm elections held this week.



As a backlash against bosses brewed in Silicon Valley, the workforce became a constituency that CEOs could no longer control

HEROES AND VILLAINS

These movies tend to have a self-flattering angle. The only people who end up looking good in *The Social Reckoning* are Frances Haugen, the engineer who leaked the Facebook Files, and Jeff Horwitz, the reporter who published them.

The moral centre of *Artificial* appears to be Ilya Sutskever, the soulful scientist who led the boardroom coup against Altman in 2023. And in *Musk*, Gibney himself is the bold truth-teller.

You Can See Everything is the outlier. The documentary doesn't fall on either side of the battle lines. It treats Holmes as an enigmatic puzzle that may or may not be unlocked by Fielder.

Perhaps that's why it's been the most successful of the lot. *You Can See Everything* took home $15 million from 855 screens, the second biggest non-music documentary debut ever, behind Michael Moore's *Fahrenheit 9/11* in 2004.

In contrast, *The Social Reckoning* opened to $5.5 million and *Musk* flopped. Perhaps, if audiences want to watch Iron Man become a supervillain, they have decided that Robert Downey Jr playing Doctor Doom in the next *Avengers* franchise sounds considerably more fun than four hours of Elon Musk on screen.

– The Washington Post

How 'Dessert Flipping' Can Make You Eat Healthier

Anahad O'Connor

Many popular desserts tend to be loaded with fat, sugar, white flour and other not-so-healthy ingredients. Nuts and fresh fruit are often just a garnish or topping. But what would happen if that ratio was flipped around? Would you still enjoy your dessert?

PIC: GETTY IMAGES



Researchers found that people preferred desserts that were mostly fresh fruit. Amalie Kurzer, lead author of the study, published in the *Journal of Food Science*, and her colleagues, call this strategy 'the dessert flip', because it flips the proportion of ingredients in the desserts.

The researchers created three scenarios. In the first, participants were given a slice of vanilla cake with a small side of berries and nuts, 80% cake by weight and 20% fruit and nuts. The second 'stealth' option was a slice of cake that had peach purée inside of it, 55% cake by weight and 45% fruit. Lastly, the 'flipped' dessert was 20% cake and 80% fruit and nuts — a thin slice of vanilla cake with a heaping side of chopped strawberries, blueberries, raspberries, blackberries and sliced almonds.

The participants liked the conventional dessert as much as the 'stealth' option. But they liked the 'flipped' dessert much more, rating it highest.

VARIETY APPEAL

Kurzer said it appeared that people preferred the 'flipped' dessert because it was more interesting, with a variety of flavours, colours and textures, as well as some crunchiness from the nuts.

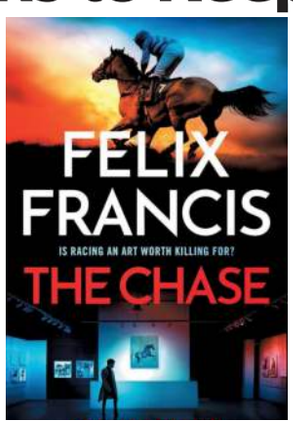
She said, "As humans, we crave variety in our diets. So, a big piece of cake gets boring fast, especially if it's a cake that you know is not necessarily good for you."

As part of the study, the researchers looked into which fruits are best suited for dessert. They found that people preferred eating mangoes and berries for dessert over other fruits. Kurzer said it isn't realistic to tell people not to eat dessert, so this strategy can help focus on moderation.

– The Washington Post

Four Books to Keep You Hooked This Weekend

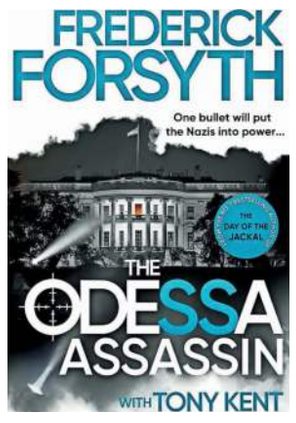
Escape into a world of suspense, where every page brings new mysteries and unexpected twists



THE CHASE by Felix Francis

Art gallery owner Fabian Tulley fears someone is trying to ruin his business when he's accused of selling a fake Alfred Munnings painting. Then, some of his other artworks are vandalised at his stand at Cheltenham racecourse and his regular clients are threatened and told to stay away from his gallery.

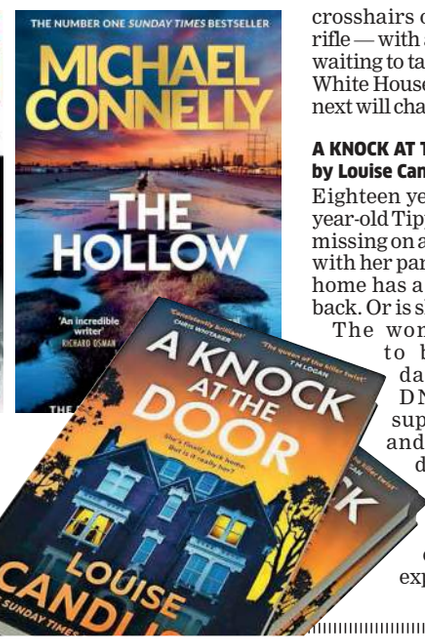
The Chase is an engaging and tense thriller providing intriguing insights into the art world, with plenty of twists and turns to keep readers gripped.



THE ODESSA ASSASSIN by Frederick Forsyth and Tony Kent

Having collaborated with Frederick Forsyth on a sequel to his acclaimed 1972 political thriller *The Odessa File* with last year's *Revenge of Odessa*, Tony Kent returns with the finale to their trilogy.

Taking place in the immediate aftermath of the first sequel, *The Odessa Assassin* shows the US president in the crosshairs of an assassin's rifle — with a group of Nazis waiting to take control of the White House. What happens next will change everything.



A KNOCK AT THE DOOR by Louise Candlish

Eighteen years after three-year-old Tippi Macklin went missing on a weekend break with her parents, the family home has a visitor. Tippi's back. Or is she?

The woman claiming to be their lost daughter says a DNA test will support her claim and the Macklins desperately want it to be her. But what follows will upend everyone's expectations.

THE HOLLOW by Michael Connelly

The neglect, loneliness and violence suffered by LA detective-turned-private investigator Harry Bosch after he was orphaned at 11 and placed in the grim MacLaren Children's Hall has cast a long shadow over his life.

Now in his 70s, the financial settlement following a class-action lawsuit against the county forces him to confront memories of 'the hollow' — the cramped, airless space where difficult children were punished.

As ever, Bosch is more interested in justice than money, specifically the death of his friend and fellow inmate 'Chops' Lamb which was covered up at the time. But can old files reveal the identity of a predator?

– Daily Mirror

PICS: GETTY IMAGES

In Goa, Diwali Means Narakasura and Poha

FOOD FABLES



VIKRAM DOCTOR

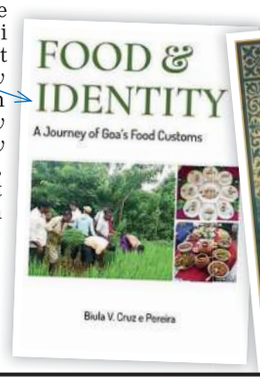
Tourists in Goa during Diwali can get confused. Why are huge demonic statues paraded, and then burned, so many days after Dussehra? But this is Narakasura, not Ravana, and the story of his defeat and his dying wish to have it celebrated with lights gets dovetailed into Diwali. In Goa, this is a big event.

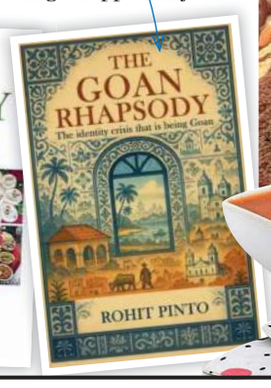
Tourists who try traditional Goan Hindu Diwali food might also be confused. There are sweets, of course, but also poha, called *fov* in Konkani. Mapusa market, in the run-up to Diwali, is crowded with temporary stalls selling diyas and freshly made poha, both the fine white and sturdier red varieties.

In Biula V Cruz e Pereira's *Food & Identity*, a study of food habits in four Goan villages, she lists common Diwali preparations: "Most families prepare *batat fov* (dry flattened poha with potatoes), *dudantle fov* (with milk), *takantle fov* (with buttermilk), *rosantle fov* (with coconut milk), *godache fov* (with jaggery), *dahiatle fov* (with curd)..."

Goan Catholics may not make all of this, but they look forward to eating it at Hindu friends' homes.

In Rohit Pinto's book *The Goan Rhapsody*, he extolls eating poha with curried hog plums, also traditionally made at this time: "The combination is heavenly, the almost crunchy, *al dente* texture of the flattened rice paired with the sweet-sour richness of the curry feels like being wrapped in your mother's comforting hug."







Poha is a seasonally appropriate dish. It is best made with newly harvested rice, which is soaked for a while, dried, roasted, and finally pounded and processed to remove the husk. Adherents of raw food diets sometimes imagine that poha is a grain that, miraculously, needs no cooking — just soak and it's ready to eat. More accurately, poha is pre-cooked, rather like cornflakes, but invented in India centuries before flaked cereals were developed in the West.

Food historian KT Achaya notes that the pre-cooking process was known in Vedic times, with parched barley mentioned in the *Rigveda*: "Parched rice is later referred to as *chipita*, a name that survives in the crisp fried snack *chivda*." He explains that this exposure to fire meant that poha was seen as a ritually pure food: "Parched grains made by professionals can be bought and used even by an orthodox Brahmin without the stigma of pollution." This might explain why poha famously features in the story of Sudama, an impoverished Brahmin who seeks help from his childhood friend Krishna. As a gift, all he has is four handfuls of poha, which he is too ashamed to give. But Krishna insists on receiving it, and richly rewards Sudama in return.

Poha is light to carry, doesn't go bad easily and is quickly cooked by soaking, all of which makes it an ideal travel food. Pilgrims have carried it across India for ages, both to sustain themselves and to offer at temples.

The British realised its value for Indian soldiers, especially when they were being sent over long distances. In 1846, *The Times of India* reported that, for the Bombay Garrison, "the commissariat department will supply only grain parched, and powa, for their use on the voyage".

There seems no clear reason why Goa associates poha with Diwali. But perhaps there's a clue here to why it links with the Ramayana which is, among other things, the story of a long journey.

In recent years, machines have been developed that grind rice into a paste and then extrude it as rice flakes. One food processing handbook suggests adding sugar or salt to make ready-sweetened or salted poha. A report from the National Institute of Food Technology, Entrepreneurship and Management, Thanjavur, lists the benefits of this machine-made poha including "empowering the lifestyle of promoter by adopting proper techniques in production and marketing of final product".

I wish the best for poha promoters, but I hope the traditional type never disappears in Goa during Diwali.

PIC: GETTY IMAGES

UP strengthens its law and order

Uttar Pradesh steps up security measures through better policing, crime prevention, technology-led surveillance and focused action against organised crime to enhance public safety

Uttar Pradesh has intensified efforts to strengthen law and order through improved policing, crime prevention and technology-driven surveillance. Under the guidance of Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath, the state has focused on tackling organised crime, curbing cyber offences and enhancing women's safety.

Cybercrime police stations are operational in all 75 districts, while cyber cells and help desks have been set up at district police stations. Measures such as anti-romeo squads, Mission Shakti centres and women PAC battalions aim to improve women's safety.

The emergency response system, UP-112, has been strengthened, with a reported response time of 5 minutes and 56 seconds. Various CCTV cameras have also been installed to enhance surveillance and assist investigations.

Action against organised crime includes proceedings under the Gangsters Act and National Security Act, seizure of illegally acquired properties and focused prosecution under Operation Conviction. Together, these measures aim to make policing more responsive, strengthen public safety and reinforce citizens' confidence in law enforcement.





PICS: DIPR, GOVT OF UP

Stronger Systems for a Safer State

FIGURE	DETAILS
5 minutes 56 seconds	Current response time of UP-112
1010	Actions taken under the NSA
43,155	Individuals against whom legal action was taken during anti-romeo operations
₹15,516 crore	Estimated value of illegal properties seized under the Gangsters Act
3	Women PAC battalions formed
5	Additional women PAC battalions in the process of formation
₹4,055 crore	Value of illegal properties seized from mafias and criminals
36+ mafias and 109 organised criminals	More than 36 mafias and 109 organised criminals secured stringent sentences through intensive prosecution
314	Criminals killed in encounters between March 20, 2017, and September 6, 2026
1,56,021	Accused persons convicted under Operation Conviction during July 1, 2023 to September 8, 2026
12,202	Criminals injured in encounters
15,917	Convictions in cases registered under the POCSO Act
24,094	Wanted criminals carrying rewards arrested and sent to jail
4,784	Convictions in rape cases

EMERGENCY HELPLINE NUMBERS

- **1030** Cyber Crime Helpline
- **1076** CM Helpline
- **101** Fire Helpline
- **1090** Women Power Helpline
- **1098** Child Helpline
- **102** Pregnant and Newborn Care Helpline
- **108** Ambulance Service
- **112** Emergency Police Service

Firm Action, Stronger Public Safety

07	Women's Police Stations
04	Water Police Outposts
75	Electricity Theft Police Stations
04	Economic Offences Unit Police Stations
06	New Narcotics Police Stations
12.50 lakh+	CCTV cameras installed under operation trinetra
95	New Police Outposts
78	Women's Police Outposts/Counselling Centres
10	Vigilance Establishment Police Stations
75	Cybercrime Police Stations
75	Anti-Human Trafficking Units converted into police stations
19,834	Women police personnel appointed

ENHANCING SECURITY ON ALL FRONTS

CHECK ON CYBERSECURITY

- Cybercrime police stations are operational in all 75 districts of the state
- Cyber cells/help desks have been established in all district police stations
- Provision for freezing/holding funds linked to cybercrime through National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal and helpline 1930



PROMPT POLICE ASSISTANCE

- UP-112 gets more resources and citizen-friendly initiatives
- A decision has been taken to launch a link service to provide a secure environment for industrial establishments
- Integration of 1090, GRP, Fire Services, and Women's Helpline 181



WOMEN'S AND GIRLS' SAFETY

- Effective operation of anti-romeo squads to curb incidents of harassment
- Establishment of Mission Shakti Centres at every police station
- Formation and expansion of women PAC battalions to strengthen women's safety
- Formation of the Women and Child Security Organisation 1090



FIGHT AGAINST ORGANISED CRIME

- Effective police action against hardened criminals
- Action under the Gangsters Act and National Security Act (NSA)
- Seizure of illegally acquired properties belonging to mafias and criminals
- Effective prosecution under Operation Conviction



READER ENGAGEMENT INITIATIVE

VITALS

IPL: Mumbai Set to Trade Hardik to Punjab for Arshdeep



New Delhi: Star all-rounder Hardik Pandya is set to move to Punjab Kings in exchange for pacer Arshdeep Singh after Mumbai Indians and Punjab Kings agreed to a trade ahead of the IPL auction later this month. The deal, however, requires BCCI ratification before it can be officially confirmed. An IPL source said the trade had been completed, adding that Hardik was happy to play under Shreyas Iyer, who will continue as Punjab Kings captain. "It was the decision of the captain and the coach to trade Hardik for Arshdeep, who has been with Punjab Kings for a long time and has developed into the player he is today through his success with the franchise," the source said. The move would bring an end to Hardik's second stint with Mumbai Indians. He returned to the franchise in the 2024 season as captain, replacing long-serving skipper Rohit Sharma. **PTI**

ISSF WORLD CHAMPIONSHIPS

India's Skeet Campaign Ends Without Medal

Doha: India's disappointing campaign at the ISSF World Championships continued on Saturday as both its skeet mixed teams failed to win a medal, with Raiza Dhillon and Mairaj Ahmad Khan finishing fourth in the four-team final. The Indian pair had raised hopes of ending the country's barren run in skeet after qualifying for the medal round with an impressive performance. But they failed to maintain that momentum in the final, where Raiza's five misses proved costly as India became the first team to be eliminated. The 22-year-old Raiza and 51-year-old Mairaj managed a combined score of 19. While Mairaj hit all 15 targets, Raiza missed five of her 15 shots, effectively ending India's medal hopes. **PTI**

Narrow Win for Arsenal, Tottenham Revival Ends at Leeds

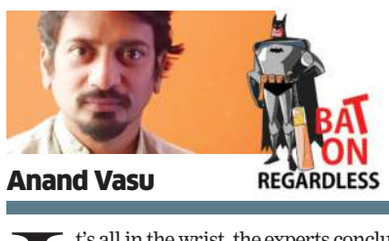
LONDON: Arsenal banked another three points in the defence of their Premier League title as their trademark persistence once again paid off in a 1-0 home win over stubborn Hull City on Saturday. It was not fluent or convincing but Martin Odegaard's poacher's goal in the 72nd-minute earned Mikel Arteta's side a sixth league win by a single-goal margin this season. Arsenal moved to 27 points from 10 games. Tottenham Hotspur's recent revival came to a halt as they went down 1-0 at Leeds United for whom Noah Okafor struck the winner 97 seconds after coming off the bench at Elland Road. There was controversy, though, with Leeds fortunate not to be reduced to 10 men in the first half when Jayden Bogle escaped a red card for a dangerous tackle on Mathys Tel. **Reuters**

WATCHOUT! Tonight

PREMIER LEAGUE **Crystal Palace v Liverpool** 7:30pm; **Sunderland v Chelsea** 7:30pm; **Man United v Aston Villa** 10pm (Star Sports) **LA LIGA** **Atlético Madrid v Barcelona** 1:30am (Fancode)

Rhythm Divine

Shami retires from Test cricket as the sixth-most successful fast bowler for India. A master of seam and swing, he possessed something no coaching manual could teach



BAT ON REGARDLESS

Anand Vasu



It's all in the wrist, the experts concluded. The supple grip, which caressed the ball rather than held it, tightened only when it needed to in the moment before delivery, and the snap put serious action on the ball, allowing the seam to stay bolt upright and act as a rudder as the red cherry traversed 22 yards, swinging ever so subtly and nipping back with rude suddenness to beat the bat.

There was a point in time when every fast bowler in the world tried to copy Mohammed Shami's wrist position. Some succeeded, but the ball didn't respond the same way it did with Shami. Where he had it on a string, not controlling it as much as convincing it to do his bidding, others let it go in hope.

It's the fast-twitch muscles that allowed him to run through the crease, finishing his action with explosive energy. It's the strength in his thighs, built through hours of solitary toil in purpose-built nets at his home in the dusty village of Amroha in Uttar Pradesh. It's the rhythm derived from repetition, purposeful practice, and probing matchplay, they said. It's in the genes; his father and brother were both fast bowlers.

They are all right, and they couldn't be more wrong at the same time.

Shami does indeed possess all the attributes you look for in a fast bowler. Some were gifts he was born with, and others he developed through hard labour, the guidance of astute coaches, the advice of teammates, and the support of well-wishers.

But Shami was not built in a laboratory. You cannot take any promising kid, apply the resources and end up with Shami, or even a version of Shami.

You cannot build into a body the resilience needed to bowl the seventh over of a spell on the fifth day of a Test match in sweltering heat with the game on the line.

You cannot coach a mind to the stillness needed to patiently set up a batsman at the top of his game, each delivery a companion to the one that preceded it, a sequence of events that the batsman is party to without knowing that he is about to become the victim of the exercise.

You cannot will into existence the stoutness of heart that marries intensity and purpose so single-mindedly that it can be summoned even when there is no light at the end of the tunnel.

Shami ends with 229 wickets in 64 Tests — statistically just outside India's top five fast bowlers — but the numbers don't tell the full story of his mastery or his value to the captains who had the luxury of tossing the ball to him when a partnership needed breaking.

On November 6, Shami ended a 13-year romance with red ball and white clothing, marking the anniversary of receiving his Test cap by hanging up his boots. Maybe numbers do mean something to him after all.

In the course of this journey, Shami was celebrated when he broke open games for India but also vilified when India lost to Pakistan, his commitment to the cause being unjustly questioned by the worst among us, simply because he is Muslim.

Shami had details of his personal life, some exaggerated, others fabricated, wrung out in public life because his celebrity could be exploited for vicarious gain by those of such a bent of mind.

I got this [Test cap] on 6th November, and today is 6th November. So, let's end this 13-year journey here today. I am leaving this [Test cricket], but I will continue to play white-ball cricket, whether it is IPL or domestic

MOHAMMED SHAMI

CAREER STATS

TESTS	WKTS
64	229

Shami overcame the trauma of his body being broken by the unnatural effort of fast bowling and repeatedly rose again, only for time to eventually catch up with the 36-year-old whose body had aged far more than those years simply through the sheer wear and tear he had subjected it to.

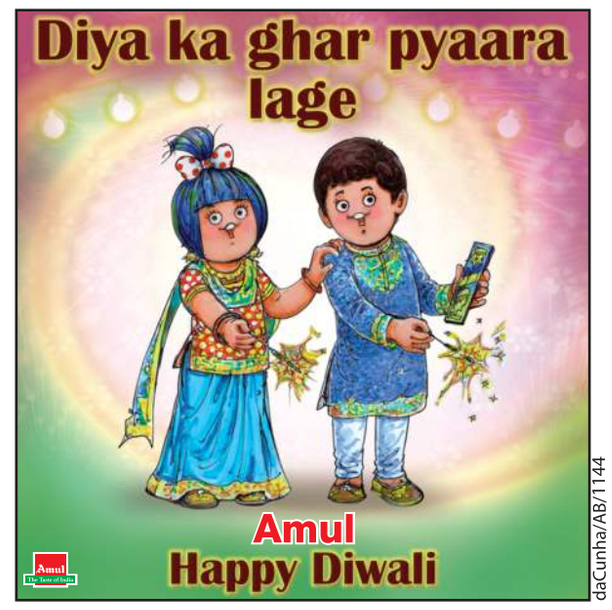
Opponents have dissected Shami's craft because their survival depended on it: but knowing why he did what he did or how was not always insurance against its efficacy. Teammates, especially aspiring young quicks, have examined his preparation and mindset, but that was no guarantee they could emulate him, even with his willing assistance. Experts have marvelled at Shami's sustained excellence, the undeniable beauty of how he cruelly exposed batsmen before getting them out.

But fans, they have had it best. To be alive at the same time as Shami was to walk with him, even briefly, on his journey: to live through him the frustrations of failure, the rigours and demands of living in this world and to experience the beauty of a man in touch with his calling.

The greatest thing about Shami was not his wrist, his intelligence or his heart. It was that he did not intellectualise; he did not invoke the sentimental, he did not ask anything of his fans.

When Shami stood at the top of his mark, the ball, an inanimate sphere of string and leather and cork, came to life, and knew that its destination was the top of off stump. As he delivered the ball, the batsman realised he was not the hero of this stage, but merely another player. As the slip cordon rose to celebrate the wicket, the loop closed, and a great game was alive and well.

At his best, Shami was the beating heart of cricket, by just his being. For this truth, the game and those that love it owe him a debt of gratitude.



'IT WAS ALL OF US'

Khawaja Makes Sensational Sandpapergate Claims

Former opener Usman Khawaja claimed on Saturday that the entire Australian team knew about the 2018 "Sandpapergate" scandal in Cape Town and said they also employed the tactic during the previous Test at Port Elizabeth.

Captain Steve Smith, his deputy David Warner and Cameron Bancroft were sent home in disgrace and found by a Cricket Australia investigation to be the only three players with prior knowledge of the ball-tampering plot.

Smith was banned for a year and sacked as skipper, Warner was suspended for 12 months and stripped of all leadership roles while Bancroft was slapped with a nine-month ban.

But Khawaja, who retired this year after 88 Tests, told the Sydney Morning Herald everyone had prior knowledge.

"It was all of us. Not the batters, not the bowlers, not the staff. All of us," he said ahead of the release of his autobiography next week where a chapter is dedicated to the issue.

Bowlers Pat Cummins, Mitchell Starc, Josh Hazlewood and Nathan Lyon all denied publicly in 2021 that they knew about it.



In an ideal world, I don't want to be the one who comes out and talks about the truth. I genuinely thought after eight years the truth would have been out by now

USMAN KHAWAJA Former Australia batter

Khawaja said he spoke in the dressing room after the Cape Town Test urging the team to take collective responsibility, rather than scapegoating Warner, Smith and Bancroft.

"In an ideal world, I don't want to do this." Khawaja said.

"I don't want to be the one who comes out and talks about the truth. The issue is that I genuinely thought after eight years the truth would have been out by now.

"Maybe I thought Davey (Warner) would have exposed it, or someone else would have talked about it more. I just didn't think it was going to come down to this."

In the book, according to the newspaper, Khawaja recounts that discussions about ways to rough up the ball were also held in the dressing room during the second Test at Port Elizabeth, now known as Gqeberha.

It culminated in the discovery that sandpaper was effective and at this point Smith allegedly walked away, saying he did not want to know about it. Bancroft then allegedly volunteered to use sandpaper in South Africa's first innings in Gqeberha, where the ball swung significantly.

Cricket Australia said in a statement it was "comfortable" with the findings of its original investigation, but remained open to new evidence.

"There has been a great deal of speculation in the eight years since the 2018 Cape Town Test, including extensive media coverage throughout last month's series in South Africa," it said.

"During this time there has been the ongoing opportunity to present any relevant information, and this remains the case.

"All relevant information presented to CA to date has been properly considered and we remain comfortable with the findings of our integrity process." **AFP**

That's part and parcel of selling books, I suppose. I don't know what he's getting paid. He's probably getting paid a lot of money to do it. Maybe I'll write a book

DARREN LEHMANN Former Australia batter & head coach

So we finally now know the most hidden secret in the game ... all the Aussie team knew about the sandpaper ... 8 yrs later it all comes out ... no sh*t Sherlock ... now can we just move on

MICHAEL VAUGHAN Former England captain

India Take 2-0 Lead After Narrow DLS Win in Low-Scoring Thriller

WELLINGTON: India edged New Zealand by four runs under the Duckworth Lewis System in the second ODI on Saturday as rain prevented a more gripping finale.

Chasing a paltry 135 for victory in a match reduced to 47 overs per side, India were 113-7 after 26 overs when the rain brought the match to an end.

Under the arcane system used to decide matches affected by rain, India were four runs ahead of a par score at the time the rain came and so took the match and a 2-0 lead in the five-match series.

The first match of the series in Auckland, which India won by five wickets after bowling out New Zealand for 185, was also affected by rain.

A thrilling finish was in prospect with India still needing 23 runs with just three wickets in hand when the rain arrived.

New Zealand had defended their small total superbly, thanks to aggressive bowling from Kyle Jamieson, who took 3-35 from 10 overs, and Jacob Duffy, who took 3-35 from 7 overs, including the early wickets of Shubman Gill for a first-ball duck and Virat Kohli for 7.



GURNOOR BRAR NAMED PLAYER OF THE MATCH FOR HIS 4/30 IN THE SECOND ODI

India's chase was assisted by Rohit Sharma, who made 23 after failing in the first match of the series, Shreyas Iyer's 30 from 46 balls and KL Rahul, who was 26 not out at the close.

India had been in trouble at 47-4 and later when they lost the consecutive wickets of Naman Dhir and Anshul Kamboj after being 86-5. The match finally ended amid a heavy shower at 11pm local time.

Earlier, Daryl Mitchell made the only half-century of the match and shared a 59-run partnership with Mitchell Santner to allow New Zealand to reach 134 after they had been 53-5.

Mitchell was out for 55 and Santner for 31 while Henry Nicholls (11) was the only other New Zealand batter to reach double figures.

Gurnoor Brar produced difficult bounce and took 4-30 from 10 overs while Auqib Nabi struck twice early and finished with 2-31. Kamboj and spinner Axar Patel, bowling through the middle of the innings, took two wickets each.

"Bowling here in New Zealand, the pace and the bounce really helps so I enjoyed it," said Brar, who was player of the match. "In India, the pitches are a bit flat so we have to bowl that hard length. But here that extra bounce is there, so I was just bowling to my strengths." **AP**

It's nice to have a little bit of a favour now again. And, I hope the viewer can appreciate some of the skill that was on show from both bowling line-ups

KYLE JAMIESON on bowler-friendly pitches in back-to-back matches

BRIEF SCORES **New Zealand** 134 all out in 41 overs (Mitchell 55, Santner 31; Brar 4/30, Kamboj 2/25, Axar 2/28, Nabi 2/31) lost to **India** 113 for 7 in 26 overs (Iyer 30, Rahul 26*; Duffy 3/35, Jamieson 3/35) by four runs (DLS method)

The Race To Be First Among Equals

World No. 1 and defending champion Rybakina faces seven challengers at an intriguing WTA Finals



Gaurav Kalra

CHIP N CHARGE



Rewind the clock by a year.

Elena Rybakina was the last player to qualify for the WTA Finals. She left Riyadh unbeaten, with the trophy and a straight-sets win over Aryna Sabalenka, then world No. 1. As this season's finale begins in Indian Wells, Rybakina will be the defending champion, the winner of two Grand Slam titles in 2026 and firmly on top of the rankings. She has gone from barging into the top echelons of the sport, to now being the leader of the pack.

Of the eight women in California, Rybakina will be most eager to get her hands on the trophy. She beat Sabalenka in both the Australian Open and US Open finals, taking over as No. 1 after the New York triumph. The authority and poise in her play has delivered 54 wins in 68 matches this year, and four titles including two majors. At Indian Wells, Rybakina can become the first woman to retain the Finals title since Serena Williams won three in a row from 2012 to 2014.

"I would like to push and finish at No. 1," Rybakina said in Beijing after her US Open win. She admitted then that things can quickly change with so many good players around.

That is what makes this tournament such a fitting test, with only the most consistent on the circuit making the cut. If she can come through this field, Rybakina's claim to being the best player in the world will have the weight of three of the season's biggest titles behind it.

For Sabalenka, now ranked two, the motivation is shaped entirely different. She won Indian Wells and Miami back-to-back and reached two major finals. For most players that would be a season to savour, but for the imposing Belarussian a year without a Slam is an underwhelming outcome. She will be hunting for her first Finals title, the biggest prize available outside the majors.

"Hopefully it will go the same way as Indian Wells in March," she said after qualifying. Sabalenka can count on the memory of having beaten Rybakina in that final and another trophy on the same courts would give her something to carry into the off-season besides the not-so-pleasant memories of having to watch Rybakina hold up the winner's trophy in Melbourne and New York.

The two other women who won majors this year are split between the groups. Mirra Andreeva, who won Roland Garros at 19, is in Sabalenka's section. She can change the pace of a rally and make a big hitter play an extra ball from an awkward position. Linda Noskova, the Wimbledon champion, is in the same group as Rybakina. Her first serve and flat backhand can take time away even from players accustomed to dictating. Both, now as first-time major champions, will be thirsting to end a memorable season with this prestigious title.

Coco Gauff's court coverage and Jessica Pegula's clean, early ball-striking give Rybakina two very different problems in the same group. Across the draw, Elina Svitolina has already made a semi-final on these courts this year, while Karolina Muchova can use her slice and her willingness to come forward to disrupt the rhythm of a group full of accomplished baseliners.

Even as these elite eight front up in the California desert, consider who is missing. Iga Swiatek, a six-time major champion, finished ninth in the race. Marta Kostyuk was next, while Maja Chwalinska, a qualifier who reached the Roland Garros final, and four-time major winner Naomi Osaka were also among those in the chasing pack.

Over the course of the week, the WTA tour Finals will be a celebration of one of the most competitive circuits in all of women's sport. Rybakina has earned the right to walk out as the first among equals, but the most intriguing sub-plot is that seven women have good reason to believe they can walk out last.

WTA FINALS

GROUP 1
[Rank] Player
[1] Elena Rybakina; [4] Coco Gauff; [5] Jessica Pegula; [8] Linda Noskova

GROUP 2
[2] Aryna Sabalenka; [3] Mirra Andreeva; [6] Elina Svitolina; [7] Karolina Muchova

HOW IT WORKS

GROUP STAGE
Eight players split into two groups
Each player plays three matches in a round-robin format

KNOCKOUT STAGE
- Top two from each group qualify for the semifinals
- Group A winner faces Group B runner-up, and vice versa. Semifinal winner advances to the final
- Champion lifts the Billie Jean King Trophy

RANKING POINTS
Round-robin win 200 points
Semifinal win 400 points
Final win 500 points

TOTAL PRIZE POOL
$10 MILLION

LIV Defectors Face Awkward Return to Tours they Abandoned

Ian Ransom

MELBOURNE: Having defected to LIV Golf for eye-watering sums of money, players from the doomed circuit may be about to discover their true market value as they seek a return to the established tours they spurned.

LIV's collapse has left dozens of golfers facing uncertain futures, though the biggest names will likely find a warmer welcome than the journeymen and fading stars who also cashed in on the Saudi-backed league's riches.

Former major champions Jon Rahm, Brooks Koepka and Patrick Reed have already turned their backs on LIV, while Australian Lucas Herbert and England's Tyrrell Hatton have also signalled their departures.

Others, including Australia's former British Open champion Cameron Smith, Dustin Johnson and Bryson DeChambeau, have yet to publicly settle their futures.

Some are owed millions of dollars under their playing contracts and may have little prospect of recovering much, if any.

LIV's bankruptcy filing listed 14 current and former players among its 30 largest unsecured creditors, with claims totalling about $45.5 million.

The list included outstanding obligations of about $5.7 million to DeChambeau and $4.8 million to Smith, a fraction of their earnings from the league and their sign-on bonuses.

Some will hope to resume earning on US PGA Tour and European DP World Tour as soon as they can but returning to the circuits they turned their backs on will not be a formality.



BRYSON DECHAMBEAU HAS YET TO PUBLICLY SETTLE HIS FUTURE

Neither tour is obliged to restore their former privileges.

The PGA Tour's existing rules provide for suspensions linked to players' last LIV appearances.

Five-times major winner Koepka was granted re-entry to the US Tour through its "returning member program" as a major winner but that door is now closed to others.

Tour boss Brian Rolapp made it clear in June that the LIV defections had been taken personally.

"There's scar tissue, and that has to be accounted for," he said.

The DP World Tour has been more accommodating, indicating it is prepared to consider membership applications and tournament invitations from returning LIV players, although outstanding fines and disciplinary matters could complicate their reinstatement.

Europe may ultimately prove an attractive interim destination for golfers shut out, at least temporarily, from the PGA Tour.

The big-name players are likely to have more clout than some of LIV's lesser lights when negotiating their returns, opening the prospect of a two-tier market.

"The likes of Jon Rahm have value. Some, like Cam Smith, may have less after seeing their form drop while on the LIV tour," said Colin Smith, principal of Melbourne-based sports media advisory firm Global Media & Sports.

LIV golfers whose best years are behind them may have to earn their way back via qualifying tournaments or return to developmental circuits.

Some players who remained loyal to the US and DP World Tours are positive about the return of LIV rivals, saying it will be good for golf after years of controversy and disruption.

Others are more measured and argue against rolling out the red carpet for the defectors. **Reuters**